Sunday, December 24, 2023
Poush 8, 2080 | Nepal Sambat 1144 | Thinllatwho Trayodashi

NATION'S 1ST ENGLISH BROADSHEET

risingnepaldaily.com
Vol. LIX, No. 8 | Pages 8 | Rs. 5 | National Edition

THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL

BIRATNAGAR IS CENTRE OF POLITICAL REVOLUTION: PRESIDENT

RSS
Biratnagar, Dec 23

President Ramchandra Paudel has laid emphasis on building self-reliant and prosperous economy.

Inaugurating the Democratic Fighters' Honor Ceremony and industrialists' conclave here on Saturday, President Paudel viewed industrialists could play important role to form socialism-oriented economy.

President Paudel informed governments' initiatives to recover the national economy dented by COVID-19 has showed positive results. He however said country's economy is not up to the mark- revenue targets are missed; and industries not operated in full scale.

He reminded various personalities who had invaluable role for democracy and freedoms in the country.

According to him, Biratnagar is the provenance of both political and industrial revolutions. It houses the oldest Biratnagar Jute Mill where the labour movement was initiated.

» SEE PAGE 6



PHOTO: RSS

President Ramchandra Paudel being honoured at the Democratic Fighters' Honor Ceremony and Industrialists' conclave in Biratnagar on Saturday.

PM urges to promote organ donation campaign

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 23



Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has urged all Nepalis to have a positive attitude towards organ transplantation and contribute to it from their respective places.

While addressing the first national transplant conference organised by the Martyr Dharma Bhakta Mathema National Transplant Centre and Organ Transplant Society Nepal in Kathmandu on Saturday, Prime Minister Prachanda said, "I have personally declared my intention to donate my organs. I urge all my brothers and sisters to consider that donating organs that turn into ashes after death could give a new life to many individuals."

Acknowledging the commendable efforts of the National Transplantation Centre in advocating for organ donation after brain death, he expressed concern about reluctance among the general public regarding such donations.

"As human beings, it is our collective responsibility to make efforts towards saving the patients grappling with the life-threatening conditions caused by the liver, kidney, heart, lung, and other organ failures," he added.

"Hence, I urge all Nepalis to actively participate from their individual place, by having a positive mindset towards the national campaign for organ transplantation," the Prime Minister said.

He further affirmed the government's commitment to extending all forms of support and cooperation to advance this significant campaign aimed at saving the patients whose lives are at risk due to organ failure.

Highlighting the significance of the conference in advancing quality healthcare, he said the conference would serve as a pivotal milestone to pave the way for more effective services in the future by addressing the complexities in the field of organ transplant.

Underscoring the conference's significance, he said the conference would play an important role in strengthening the nation's health services.

This conference of the organ transplantation experts to exchange both national and international experiences stands as a crucial platform to confront with the challenges prevalent in the field of organ transplants, he added.

Prime Minister Prachanda said, "The suggestions and conclusions drawn from this conference will hold a significant importance in driving qualitative transformation within our health services."

He said the government was dedicated to implement improvements in this realm based on the recommendations and outcomes derived from the conference.

He further said that during his second tenure as Prime Minister, a decision was made to allocate land for the expansion of Martyr Dharma Bhakta Mathema National Transplant Centre.

"The government remains committed to completing the pending tasks concerning this matter within his tenure," he added.

Once successful in Nepal, bio-gas could still be alternative to LP gas

- Installation of bio-gas plants falls to 10,000 a year from 40,000
- Low subsidy, migration, urbanization slow installation

BY MODNATH DHAKAL
Kathmandu, Dec. 23



The 15th Periodic Plan of Nepal implemented in the fiscal year (FY) 2019/20 had envisaged installing 200,000 domestic bio-gas (DBG) plants.

It also had a plan to replace about 40,000 tonnes of Liquefied Petroleum Gas (LPG) through the installation of 500 large biogas plants.

TRN SPECIAL

The second Nationally Determined Contribution (NDC), 2020 included the same plan with a strategy to install an additional 200,000 household biogas plants and 500 large scale biogas (LBG) plants by 2025.

But the country currently has altogether 419,779 domestic bio-gas plants and 348 large biogas plants.

Meanwhile, the government as well as international donors' support to bio-gas, which has been one of the major sources of alternative renewable energy and low-carbon technology, has significantly fallen over the years.

Increasing migration to cities, rising construction cost and diminishing support from the donors and government have detrimental impacts on the development and growth of bio-gas plants in Nepal.

Now, the Alternative Energy Promotion Centre (AEPC), the regulatory and implementing agency in the alternative energy sector, has no donors working with it in the bio-gas sector.

Earlier, institutions like the SNV Netherland Development Organisation, World Bank and TFW Germany were providing financial and technical supports to the AEPC.

Nepal once witnessed the construction of about 40,000 bio-gas plants in a year, but now the number has fallen to below 10,000. The AEPC has a target to construct 10,000 plants this fiscal year 2023/24, but is not hopeful of meeting the target.

To meet this target, about Rs. 300 million is needed, but the alternative energy promotion body has the budget of only Rs. 50 million for subsidy.

A success story

Bio-gas sector is one of the areas that Nepal excelled and the country exported its GGC 2017 model in bio-gas plant construction to various African countries as well, said Nawa Raj Dhakal, Executive Director of the AEPC.

About a decade ago, construction of bio-gas plant started revolutionising the rural areas in Nepal by providing clean energy through inexpensive methods. The government provided a good amount of grant covering more than half of the construction cost of the bio-gas plant.

In 1999/2000, a bio-gas plan would cost about Rs. 15,000 and entire money would be subsidised by the government, said Bishnu Prasad Poudel, who worked at a private-biogas company then.

According to him, there was a huge attraction to the bio-bas plant as many families in his work area in Nawalparasi (West) used to rear cattle and work in farms.

But now, the number of families involved in animal husbandry has been significantly reduced, and even in the dairies in villages one can see higher number of people coming to buy milk than to sell it.

Some households in Bardaghat Municipality of Nawalparasi West have abandoned bio-gas plants in their courtyards and LPG cylinder has become a permanent feature of their kitchen. This has been a trend across the country, said Dhakal.

While the cost of construction materials went up significantly after the 2015 earthquake, the government subsidy began decreasing. The government did not show interest in providing subsidy for the construction of bio-gas plants after the development partners pulled their hands out from the project.

Need of 70 per cent subsidy

As per Dhakal, the current government grant covers only 25 to 30 per cent of the total construction cost of the bio-gas plant.

The AEPC had proposed to raise this subsidy to 50 to 60 per cent to promote bio-gas and attract households to this, but it was not approved.

President of Nepal Bio-gas Promotion Association (NBPA), Prakash Subedi, said that the subsidy should be increased up to 70 per cent of the total cost of the plant. Currently, it costs about Rs. 80,000 in average for the construction of a bio-gas plant.

Meanwhile, the bio-gas project of Nepal has been included in the Clean Development Mechanism (CDM) and the country is receiving about Rs. 2 billion a year, said Subedi.

According to the United Nations Framework Convention on

» SEE PAGE 6

We are still in transitional phase: Deuba

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 23



Nepali Congress president Sher Bahadur Deuba has said that the country has still been in a transitional phase politically.

Speaking at the inaugural session of the NC Bagmati Province conference held in Kathmandu on Saturday, Deuba recalled the NC's lead role to establish inclusive proportional democratic system.

"The system provisioned representation of the Aadibasi Janajati, disabled and others in the state mechanisms," he said. The NC chief said the NC regained the position of the largest party from the last general election as the present electoral system does not allow a single party to secure a majority.

He underlined the need for unity in the party to make the NC stronger from grassroots. "I would like to urged leaders of Bagmati Province to play more lead role to lead all Nepal," he said.

"The NC succeeded to become the largest party due to our friends' sacrifice and hard work. Friends, you all should involve to make the party strong from grassroots," he said.

Deuba stressed the importance of developing the feeling of cooperation between each other in the party by forging reconciliation. He said the party have leaders and workers who have contributed to the NC without any expectation.

» SEE PAGE 6

Govt has prioritised good governance: Minister Sharma

BY OUR CORRESPONDENTS
Dharan / Hile, Dec. 23



Minister for Communication and Information Technology Rekha Sharma has said that the government media is just not of government alone but of all, and they should disseminate the messages of the government to the public and vice versa.

Road to Justice

Speaking at a press conference in Sunsari on Saturday, Minister Sharma said that good governance and service delivery would be prioritised. She said that the government had been successful in taking legal action against those taking fake Bhutanese refugees to the United States, against the gold smugglers, and those involved in Lalita Niwas land scam. She said that in a democracy, everyone should be treated equally.

Minister Sharma said that the government and private sectors should move hand in hand for the development of information technology. Stating that the government would work in the areas of policy, law and infrastructure construction for the development of information and communication technology, she said that new policies were also being formulated.

» SEE PAGE 6

Chatty robot helps seniors fight loneliness through AI companionship

AP
Coral Spings, Dec. 23

Joyce Loaiza lives alone, but when she returns to her apartment at a Florida senior community, the retired office worker often has a chat with a friendly female voice that asks about her day.

A few miles away, the same voice comforted 83-year-old Deanna Dezern when her friend died. In central New York, it plays games and music for 92-year-old Marie Broadbent, who is blind and in hospice, and in Washington state, it helps 83-year-old Jan Worrell make new friends.

The women are some of the first in the country to receive the robot ElliQ, whose creators, Intuition Robotics, and senior assistance officials say is the only device using artificial intelligence specifically designed to alleviate the loneliness and isolation experienced by many older Americans.

"It's entertaining. You can actually talk to her," said Loaiza, 81, whose ElliQ in suburban Fort Lauderdale nicknamed her "Jellybean" for no particular reason. "She'll make comments like, 'I would go outside if I had hands, but I can't hold an umbrella.'"

The device, which looks like a small table lamp, has an eyeless, mouthless head that lights up and swivels. It remembers each user's interests and their conversations, helping tailor future chats, which can be as deep as the meaning of life or as light as the horoscope.

ElliQ tells jokes, plays music and provides inspirational quotes. On an accompanying video screen, it provides tours of cities and museums. The device leads exercises, asks about the owner's health and gives reminders to take medications and drink water. It can also host video calls and contact relatives, friends or doctors in an emergency.

Intuition Robotics says none of the conversations are heard by the company, with the information staying on each owner's device.

Intuition Robotics CEO Dor Skuler said the idea for ElliQ came before he launched his Israeli company eight years ago. His widowed grandfather needed an aide, but the first didn't work out. The replacement, though, understood his grandfather's love of classical music and his "quirky sense of humor."

Skuler realized a robot could fill that companionship gap by adapting to each senior's personality and interests.

"It's not just about (ElliQ's) utility. It's about friendship, companionship and empathy," Skuler said. "That just did not exist anywhere."

The average user interacts with ElliQ more than 30 times daily, even six months after receiving it, and more than 90% report lower levels of loneliness, he said.

The robots are mostly distributed by assistance agencies in New York, Florida, Michigan, Nevada and Washington state, but can also be purchased individually for $600 a year and a $250 installation fee. Skuler wouldn't say how many ElliQs have been distributed so far, but the goal is to have more than 100,000 out within five years.

That worries Brigham Young University psychology professor Julianne Holt-Lunstad, who studies the detrimental effects loneliness has on health and mortality.



PHOTO: SAGAR BASNET/TRN

A beautiful view of a village and the mountain on the road in Makawanpur.

NEA cuts off power supply to 4 industries

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 23

The Nepal Electricity Authority (NEA) has cut off the lines of four large industries with the highest arrears. According to the Authority, the lines of Jagdamba Steels, Reliance Spinning Mills, Ghorahi Cement and Arghakhanchi Cement were cut on Friday.

The electricity tariff arrears under the dedicated line of Jagdamba Steels stood at Rs. 4.14 billion, Reliance Spinning Mills at Rs. 1.94 billion, Ghorahi Cement at Rs. 1.36 billion and Arghakhanchi Cement at Rs. 1.3 billion, said the NEA.

These arrears amount includes fines as well.

Manoj Silwal, deputy managing director of Nepal Electricity Authority, said that the Authority has started cutting the power supply of industries that have not paid the electricity tariff of the dedicated line for a long time. He said that 61 industries have not paid their dues under the trunk and dedicated line facilities.

According to the Authority, under the dedicated and trunk lines, 61 industries have to pay arrears above Rs. 22 billion.

There is a long-standing dispute between the businessmen and the Authority over the arrears of the dedicated feeder and trunk line.

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal Prachanda on Thursday directed the Nepal Electricity Authority to collect the arrears of the dedicated line at any cost on the controversial issue between the industrialists and the Authority.

From August 2015, the industrialists started taking the facility of trunk and dedicated line. Some industries got this facility when the country was facing load shedding for 18 hours a day during the power crisis.

According to the Authority, the principal amount is Rs. 20 billion and with the interest and fines, arrears reached above Rs. 22 billion. The provision of dedicated and trunk lines was cancelled by the Electricity Regulatory Commission in August 2020.

By issuing new tariffs, the Commission removed the previous system of selling electricity at high prices in the name of dedicated and trunk lines. Earlier, the NEA had issued the notice and asked the businessmen to pay the arrears under the dedicated lines. After that, the businessmen met Prime Minister Prachanda and requested not to cut the electricity lines of these industries.

Accordingly, the NEA withdrew its decision adhering to the Prime Minister's direction for some time. But now, the NEA started cutting lines in those industries.

The Authority will gradually cut lines of the industries that do not pay the dues under the dedicated and trunk lines. The Authority has launched a nationwide arrears recovery campaign, he said.

According to Electricity Tariff Collection Regulations 2078, if a client does not pay the tariff within 15 days of the meter reading, the fine starts from the 16th day.

There will be a 5 per cent fine between 16-30 days of meter reading, a 10 per cent fine from 31-40 days, and a 25 per cent fine from 41st days of meter reading.

If a client fails to pay the tariff even within 60 days, a 25 per cent fine is levied and the regulation provisions for cutting off the power supply.

Narayangadh-Muglin road to be closed for four hours from today

RSS
Chitwan, Dec. 23

To allow work on chopping off a cliff to build a bridge over the Tuin River, the Narayangadh-Muglin road section will be closed for traffic for four hours a day starting from Saturday.
The road will be closed from 11:00 am to 3:00 pm.

Vehicles plying on the section of the road will be stopped at six different places in Chitwan and Tanahu. Among the vehicles going to Muglin from Narayangadh, passenger vehicles can ply from Pandhrakilo Bazaar to Jugedi till 10:40 am while cargo vehicles can ply from Bhateri to Ramnagar till 10:30 am, said Information Officer of the Narayangadh-Muglin Road Project, West Section Krishna Acharya.

Likewise, passenger vehicles coming from Kathmandu can be driven up to Muglin Bazaar till 10:55 am and cargo vehicles till 10:45 am.

Passenger vehicles coming from Pokhara will be stopped at Benitar from 10:55 am.

In the first phase, the road will be closed for three weeks. The 60 meter high mountain was downsized by 25 meters last year and the remaining 35 meters will be cleared off now, said Acharya.

More than 10,000 vehicles pass through this road section every day. Meanwhile, the District Traffic Police Office Chitwan has requested all travelers to use alternative route as the road section will be closed for traffic for four hours, leading to the possibility of traffic jam.

Seed bank established to preserve indigenous crops



PHOTO: TRN

Authorities of the Cooperative inaugurating seed bank in Waling, Syangja on Saturday.

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Waling, Dec. 23

A Seed Bank, also known as the Seed Collection and Conservation Centre, has been inaugurated in Syangja to preserve indigenous crops.

In response to the alarming disappearance of indigenous crops, a seed bank has recently been established in Waling Municipality-8 to preserve these valuable indigenous crop varieties.

Waling Product Holding Multi-Purpose Cooperative, in partnership with Waling Municipality, the United Nations Development Organization (UNDP), Diyalo and various other collaborators, has successfully established a seed bank.

Deputy Resident Representative for UNDP Nepal Julien Chevillard, Mayor of Waling Municipality Krishna Khand and outgoing Mayor Dilip Pratap Khand have jointly inaugurated the seed bank.

Addressing the event, Chevillard emphasized that safeguarding the traditional farming system is a collective responsibility.

He said, "Conservation and cultivation of traditional seeds should be done simultaneously."

Stating that the UNDP prioritizes good governance, inclusive economic development, and environment-friendly city campaigns pursued by Waling Municipality, he expressed the intention to further fortify cooperation in these areas for mutual progress.

Mayor Khand informed the public about the current initiatives and programmes aimed at preserving and safeguarding indigenous crops.

Yam Bahadur Gurung, the chairman of the cooperative said that they had successfully gathered 56 varieties of indigenous crop seeds that are on the verge of extinction in Syangja district.

Gurung also mentioned that work is ongoing to identify and collect additional seeds facing a similar threat of disappearance.

During this year, the cooperative extended support for the cultivation of five distinct types of indigenous paddy seeds, namely Pakhe Jarneli, Anadi, Kalo Jhinua, Rato Jhinua, and local Jethobudo.

Chairman Gurung informed that farmers from different areas across the district are actively engaged in supporting and supplying paddy seeds that are on the verge of disappearance.

Project agreement through ward offices

BY SUJAN KAFLE
Charikot, Dec. 23

Tamakoshi Rural Municipality of Dolakha has reached its wards to sign development project agreements.

As per the approved budget and programmes for the fiscal year 2023/24, the projects to be carried out by the local consumer committees and selected by the rural municipality and wards have been signed reaching the wards.

Badri Prasad Sharma Wagle, the Chief Administrative Officer of Tamakoshi Rural Municipality, said that the municipal-level plans allocated from the Rural Municipality Office and ward-level plans selected by the wards have been signed reaching the respective wards.

Tamakoshi Rural Municipality has seven wards, and the agreement signing process started from Ward No. 1. The rural municipality informed that the agreement was being carried out in the remaining wards as well.

"If the agreement is signed on the same day, the work can be completed effectively on time, it would be convenient for the consumer committee, and the need to visit the Rural Municipality Office to sign the agreement will end," said Wagle.

> Consumers would feel easy as they can meet the concerned person at the ward office and sign the agreement on their respective ward.

Giri further informed that to identify the right consumers the project agreement will be started as a campaign in every ward.

Consumers would feel easy as they can meet the concerned person at the ward office and sign the agreement on their respective ward, he said

"It is a kind of mobile service. The representatives of the consumer committee visit the office only for payment after finishing the work, the need to visit the ward office frequently for the same work has been reduced", he said. "To carry out development work, there is an obligation to visit rural municipalities to sign project agreement forming consumer committee," said Prona Pratap KC the ward chairman.

DEADLINE OF TOURIST ROAD CONSTRUCTION EXPIRES

RSS
Channa (Bajhang), Dec. 23

It has been one and half year since the deadline of construction of a tourist road expired in Bajhang district, but much to the dismay of local residents, the project has not inched towards any progress so far. The track for the road has not been opened yet owing to gross negligence of the construction company. The construction of road named 'Khaptad Touristic Road' stretching from Darugaun in Khaptadchanna rural municipality to the base area (Lokhada) of Khaptad has been in limbo.

The Sudurpaschim provincial government had allocated the budget for the same in the fiscal year 2019/2020. MP Constructions was awarded contract at Rs 4.6 million to open a track for the road in December, 2020. The construction company has already received Rs 984,000 as the first installment for the undertaking, but gone out of contact since then, locals complained.

Chief engineer at the Infrastructure Development Office, Junga Bahadur Thapa, shared that they had been repeatedly following up with the focal person of the construction company but to no avail.

Construction of Hetauda-Inaruwa 400kV transmission line in progress

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Sarlahi, Dec. 23

The work of the Hetauda-Dhalkebar-Inaruwa 400 kV transmission line project, which has been stalled for seven years in Lalbandi Municipality-12, Jiyajor of Sarlahi, has progressed.

The work had stopped in the Jiyajor area for seven years due to obstruction of the locals regarding the conflict over the distribution of land compensation. The foundations of eight towers are yet to be dug in this place, while the foundations of three towers have already been laid.

After many discussions with the locals, the dispute over compensation has yet not been resolved, and now security personnel have been deployed for the construction of towers. Since last Wednesday, under the security of the Nepal Police and the Armed Police, construction of the foundation of the Tower has been ongoing in full swing.

Shyam Kumar Yadav, chief of the Hetauda-Dhalkebar-Inaruwa 400 kV transmission project, said that the work that halted in the Jiyajor section has moved forward. Under the Dhalkebar-Hetauda section of this transmission line, the work stopped at Jiyajor in Sarlahi and Hatiya in Makwanpur due to the obstruction of locals.

Among them, the work of the Jiyajor area has progressed. The Nepal Electricity Authority has planned to complete the entire work of the transmission line within the next three months.

After the Nepal Electricity Authority started the work by deploying the police, the locals went to the District Administration Office, Sarlahi on Thursday and again demanded the proper compensation.

Durga Bahadur Ale Magar, ward chairman of Lalbandi Municipality-12, who reached the District Administration Office with the locals, said that attention has been drawn to address the demands of the residents.

Ward chairman said that they have demanded compensation for the acquisition of the land where the tower will be located, along with the compensation for the land occupied by the wires and also for the crops that will be damaged.

There has been no disturbance from the locals in the Jiyajor area for the past three days, and construction work is going on smoothly. Chief District Officer of Sarlahi, Komal Prasad Dhamala said that the work has progressed after the locals were explained about the benefits of the transmission line.



PHOTO: JANARJAN KHATRI/TRN

A bulldozer digging a hole for the erection of a transmission tower.

Despite falling temperatures, dengue still a threat

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 23

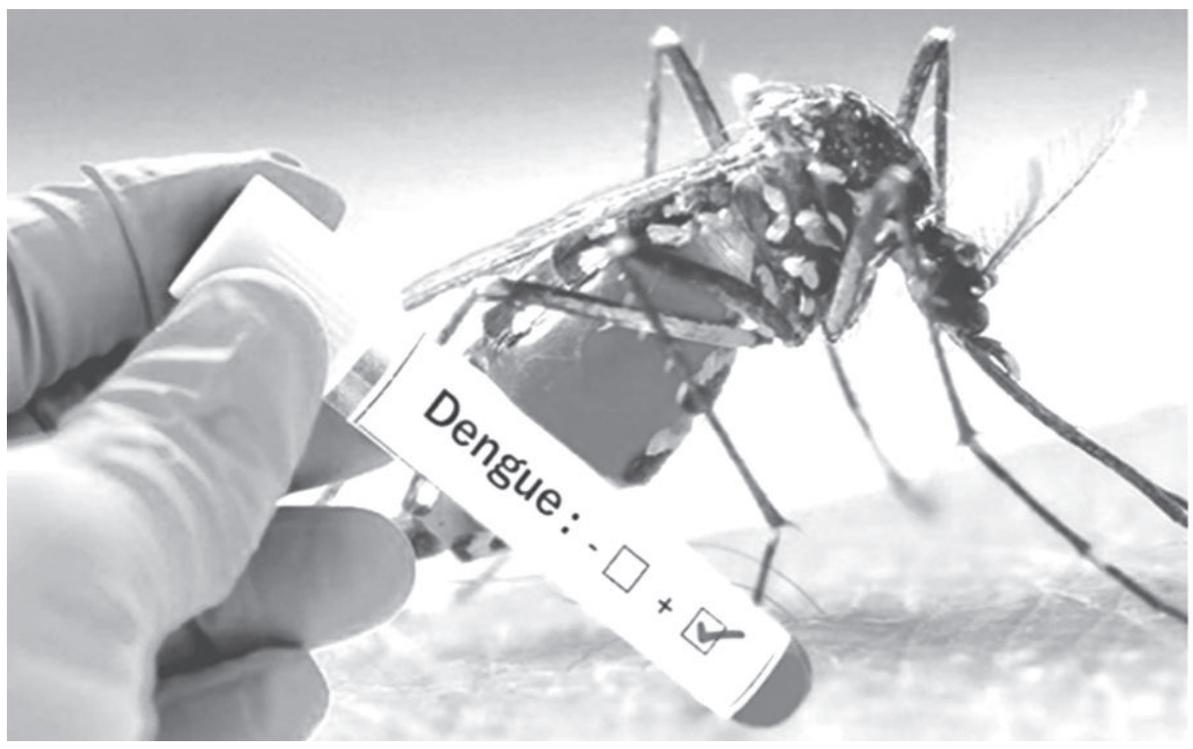


PHOTO: TRN

'Aedes aegypti mosquitoes generally survive for 28 days and cannot survive below 16 degrees Celsius.'

Even with the dip in temperature, especially in the hilly and mountainous region, vector-borne diseases, mainly dengue, are still being seen.

According to a report published by the Epidemiology and Disease Control Division the total cases of dengue across the country till December 15 was 291.

Dr Prakash Prasad Shah, Vector Borne disease specialist at the Department of Health Service, said that the reason for dengue transmission during the winter season was mainly because of climate change.

"Aedes aegypti mosquitoes generally survive for 28 days and cannot survive below 16 degrees Celsius. The current cases we are witnessing are from mosquitoes which were conceived around a month ago when the temperature was warmer.

With climate change and warmer temperatures, mosquitos are surviving in the coldest areas, so we must take precautions throughout the year." he added.

Mosquitoes, ticks, flies, fleas, lice and sandflies which were previously found only in the terai area are now found easily in upper hills and mountain regions.

"Nowadays we are finding more insects like mosquitoes, flies and sandflies in the hilly and mountainous regions. This is because of rising temperatures.

Earlier we used to find diseases like dengue and Kala-azar only in the madhes region, but now these diseases are causing more havoc in the hilly region," said Shah.

A report by the United Nations "Climate Change 2022: Impacts, Adaptation and Vulnerability" says that at least six major vector-borne diseases have recently emerged in Nepal and are now considered endemic, with climate change responsible as the main driver.

The report also shows increasing evidence that global warming has extended the high-altitude circulation of Anopheles, Culex and Aedes mosquitoes, which carry viruses, above 2,000 metres in Nepal.

"With the dip in temperature, infection from dengue and other vector diseases may decrease, but it is always wise to take precautions against these kinds of diseases. Wearing full-sleeved clothes, and sleeping under a net, especially during the warmer season, is always advised. Mosquitos do not generally survive in cold the infection rate will gradually decrease during the coming months," informed Shah.

"Dengue has four variants, and if a person is infected with one strain, then they are immune to that strain, but if they are infected again with another strain then severe health conditions can occur.

Currently, Nepal does not administer any dengue vaccine, but some countries give dengue vaccine to reduce the severity of infection," informed Shah.

The rise in vector-borne diseases has become a major public health problem in Nepal. Therefore, people and authorities should be aware of the changing pattern of vector disease and seek precautions to be safe from it.

SINGH INITIATES WORK TO CREATE GIRL-FRIENDLY ENVIRONMENT

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 23

Minister for Health and Population Minister of Madhes Province Birendra Prasad Singh has initiated a mission to create a girl-friendly environment in the region.

Teenage girls from a community school in Parsagadhi Municipality engaged in the 'I am a Child, not a Bride' campaign have gone to meet Minister Singh.

Around 110 teenage girls formed a Vision Club focusing on discussions regarding menstrual hygiene, sexual and reproductive health rights, combating child marriage and enhancing child participation in schools.

Madhu Yadav, the club's leader, emphasised that girl-centric conversations alone would not suffice in making the city and province girl-friendly.

In a bid to support this objective, the girls formalised a friendship pact with Minister Singh, who expressed his commitment to addressing social, mental, and sexual health issues encountered by girls and teenagers in Madhesh Province.

The Integrated Rural Health Development Training Centre has been facilitating orientation programmes in Parsagarhi to raise awareness and enhance the capacities of girls. Collaboratively, the Vision Club is working to create a safe space for girls to openly discuss their concerns.

Political parties in Bardibas united to oppose extraction of riverine materials from Ratu River

MAHESH KUMAR DAS
Jaleshwar, Dec. 23



The political leaders of Bardibas Municipality have united to oppose the extraction of construction materials from Ratu Khola.

After the Bardibas Municipality awarded a contract to excavate various sections of the Ratu River flowing within the city area, the political parties protested.

The representatives of various political parties on Friday united against the mining of Ratu River, urging the municipality to halt the excavation work immediately.

Raju Khadka of CPN (Maoist Centre), Chiranjeebi Hamal of Nepali Congress, Shankar Mahato of CPN-UML, Suresh Raut of CPN (Unified Socialist), Chet Kumar Thapa of LOSPA Nepal, Bimlesh Mahato of Janamat Party, Parshuram Basnet of Rastriya Swatantra Party, and Yanikhar Gautam of Rastriya Prajatantra Party published a joint statement against the mining in the Ratu River.

In the joint statement, the political parties have warned that if the excavation is not stopped immediately, they will initiate a strike against the municipality.

Bardibas Municipality has allowed the extraction of riverine materials from the Ratu River.

The municipality on August 10, 2023, issued a public notice for tender for fiscal year 2023/24 regarding the Ratu River project.

Bardibas Municipality has issued a public notice calling for e-bidding for the excavation of materials from the riverbed of Ratu River by paying Rs. 14,138,635 for 80150.99 cubic meters in the Kisan Nagar section.

Similarly, the municipality has called for the excavation of 80,115.45 cubic (ghana) meter riverbed at Jurey tole section by paying Rs. 14,132,366, Rs. 16,900,722 for the excavation of 67,288.69 cubic meter at Phulbari tole section and Rs. 11,841,722 for the excavation of 67,127.46 cubic meter at Pathlaiya section of Ratu River.

The municipality granted the tender to Dev Bishnu Construction and Suppliers Pvt. Ltd for the excavation of reverbed materials of Kisan Nagar section, Jure tole and Phulbari tole.

The tender amounted to Rs. 18.2 million for the Kisan Nagar section, Rs. 18 million for the Jure tole section, and Rs. 15.1 million for the Phulbari tole section.

Similarly, the municipality granted the tender to Rajesh and Brothers Construction and Suppliers for the excavation of the Pathlaiya River section at the cost of Rs. 13 million.

Political leaders of the municipality have initiated protests following the commencement of excavation work by the construction companies.

Due to the Ratu River's significance as the primary river in the Mahotari district, directly impacting the Chure, Bhawar, and Terai regions within its river system, a demand has been raised to immediately halt the excavation work to protect the region.

This request has been forwarded to the relevant authorities and bodies.

The statement mentioned that the Ratu River has a special relationship with human civilization as well as with the people of the Mahottari and Dhanusha districts.

Additionally, they emphasized to the relevant authorities that the government has allocated a significant budget, amounting to billions, for Chure conservation and the management of the Ratu River system and its watershed.

In the past, the various local levels under this river system including Bardiwas Municipality have been exploiting the Ratu River by granting contracts to crusher companies to excavate materials from riverbeds. Similarly, crusher mafias have also been accused of exploiting the river, treating it merely as a source of earning.

The political parties have concluded that due to haphazard excavation, the Ratu River faces a depletion of water during the winter season.

As a result of unorganized and non-scientific river mining practices, the water source started drying up.

This situation has resulted in arable lands facing desertification and locals facing severe water and food crises, the statement added.

The unnatural deepening of the river caused by excavation has led to the flooding and erosion of thousands of bighas of arable land during the rainy season.

Similarly, the political parties argued that environmental issues stemming from crusher companies operating below the set standards within the municipality are escalating.

Stating that preserving the Chure as a water reservoir is imperative since it plays a significant role in sustaining life, political parties urged Bardibas Municipality to promptly stop the haphazard excavation in Ratu River, which is causing destruction.

The contract awarded in the fiscal year 2020/21 has faced controversy over allegations of illegal mining. As a result, the case is currently pending in Janakpur High Court.

As per the environmental impact assessment conducted in 2021, an agreement was reached to extract 121,500 cubic meters of riverbed material from four sections of the Ratu River: Kisannagar, Pathalaiya, Jure tole, and Phulbari tole.

However, based on the report from the survey sub-committee, the crusher companies, including Panchadhuramai Suppliers, Shivam Construction Pvt. ltd and Dibyanshu Builder Pvt. Ltd, entrusted with the excavation has reportedly extracted seven times more material than what was mentioned in the contract.

Panchadhuramai Suppliers, which excavated riverbed materials beyond the contracted amount, is left to pay more than Rs. 27.5 million in revenues from the Kishannagar section and Rs. 16.1 million from the Jure tole section.

Likewise, Shivam Construction and Dibyanshu Builders are left to pay revenue of Rs. 27.5 million and 47.8 million respectively.

On June 8, a complaint was lodged in the Commission for Investigation of Abuse of Authority (CIAA) against the excavation activities carried out ignoring Stone, Gravel, Sand Excavation, Sale and Management Act, 2077.

At a time when the case is pending in Janakpur High Court, the legitimacy of the contract awarded by the municipality has been questioned.

People crossing Karnali by paying Rs. 100

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Humla, Dec. 23



PHOTO: TRN

A man crossing the mighty Karnali River on a tuin by paying a fare of Rs 100 per turn.

People crossing the Karnali River on a tuin, a traditional wire bridge made to cross the river, need to pay a fare of Rs. 100.

A local businessperson in Lyapche of Sarkegard Rural Municipality-2 constructed the tuin over the Karnali River at his investment and has been collecting fares from individuals.

Saroj Rawat had crossed the river by paying Rs. 100 for the tuin. He said that since the tuin saves one and a half hours of walking, people are willing to use it.

The tuin can hold up to two passengers at a time and tickets need to be purchased before riding it.

Malik Bir Bahadur Thapa, owner of the tuin, has been collecting fares by transporting people and goods. He said that he started the service a few days ago with a personal investment. He charges Rs. 100 per person and Rs. 2 per kilogram of goods.

Thapa has employed five workers paying each Rs. 1,000 daily to operate the tuin. He said that approximately 80 – 90 passengers use the tuin daily.

Additionally, the goods of the Food Management and Trading Company Limited which used to be transported via road earlier, now are being transported via tuin.

'National Transplant Centre to get land soon'

RSS
Kathmandu, Dec. 23

> We will provide land in Bhaktapur and Nagarjun soon for the expansion of the Centre. The Ministry is committed to address this issue as soon as possible.

Minister for Health and Population, Mohan Bahadur Basnet, has said government had initiated process to provide land required for the expansion of Martyr Dharmabhakta National Transplant Centre (MDNTC).

At the first National Transplant Conference jointly organised by MDNTC and Nepalese Society of Organ Transplant, here today, Minister Basnet mentioned that the process to provide land to the centre was forwarded following the direction of Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda'.

"We will provide land in Bhaktapur and Nagarjun soon for the expansion of the Centre. The Ministry is committed to address this issue as soon as possible", he vowed.

The Minister pointed out the need of immediate amendment to Medical Education Act to prevent human resources crunch in health sector in future.

Similarly, a member of the House of Representatives, Rajendra Pandey, laid emphasis on amendment of the Medical Education Act, as problem had surfaced in producing technical human resources in health sector.

Seventy-three nursing colleges were closed in lack of amendment to the Act, according to him.

Likewise, former minister Mahesh Basnet, lawmaker Ranju Jha, Centre Director Dr Pukar Chandra Shrestha, emphasized on making the Centre modern and well-equipped.

THOUGHT FOR TODAY

The best preparation for tomorrow is doing your best today.
-- H. Jackson Brown

EDITORIAL

Electricity Infrastructure

Nepal is making strides in electricity generation, with over 95 per cent of the people now having an access to it. Much of that comes through the national grid. The nation has seen power consumption grow by 15 per cent annually in recent years. Its supply to industrial sector is likely to grow if transmission lines are further expanded and reliable supply is guaranteed. The other day, Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal Prachanda inaugurated the 400kV Gas Insulated System (GIS)-based substation in Inaruwa, Sunsari – a milestone in strengthening power transmission and distribution system. This substation will enhance the capacity of the Nepal Electricity Authority (NEA) to distribute increased power at home and export it abroad. Constructed by National Electricity Development Decade Programme in joint investment of the government and the NEA, the Inaruwa substation is also the largest after Dhalkebar substation.

The power transmission infrastructure is as important as power generation itself. Without reliable infrastructure like this, the goal of national electrification and smooth power supply as well as power export cannot be achieved. Prime Minister Prachanda said that the construction of this infrastructure has generated hope amid widespread despair and it would contribute to the country's development and prosperity. Inaruwa substation can be the backbone for transmission of electricity produced by hydropower projects in various districts of Koshi Province for local consumption and export to India. NEA managing director Kul Man Ghising said that this facility is deemed significant for providing exclusive power to the industries situated in the Morang-Sunsari Industrial Corridor and enhancing the standard and reliability of electricity transmission.

There was a time when Nepalis had to bear load-shedding for up to 18 hours a day, but now they mostly have uninterrupted supply of electricity, thanks to NEA's efficient management that is now focused on developing electricity infrastructure to ensure self- sufficiency inside the country and export the surplus. The substation will go a long a way to improve electricity infrastructure and make the transmission system free from hitches. Electricity is the prerequisite for the development and sound transmission system is essential for smooth power supply functioning. The NEA's rigorous effort to improve electricity infrastructure deserves appreciation, and the people should heed its requests to consume more and more electricity. Hydropower is clean energy and its consumption is environment friendly and can also help save billions the country is spending every month to import fossil fuels.

The government ought to prioritise electricity use in agriculture, industries, cooking, and transportation sector to reduce dependency on fossil fuels responsible for the greenhouse emissions. Nepal has pledged to attain a net-zero emission by 2045, and increase the share of clean energy in total energy demand to 15 per cent and forest cover to 45 per cent by 2030. The construction of electricity infrastructure like the substation shows that Nepal is making impressive headway in power infrastructure, increasing its prospect to sell more electricity. Nepal has bright electrified future, and the achievement made in the electricity sector shows the nation's commitment to sustainable development. It is headed to be self-reliant not only in meeting domestic energy need but also going to emerge as a key player in the regional energy trade.

Upholding Dignity Of Mass Media

PARMESHWAR DEVKOTA

Johannes Gutenberg invented the printing press in 1440 AD, and used it for commercial use in 1454. As he began publishing newspapers, the human civilisation took a new turn. The newspapers began exposing the secret deals of corruption, anomalies and mismanagement between the rulers and the papal circle to the common people.

Along with that the indigenous people, slaves and the people under religious and other suppressions began realising that they had serious cause to fight for their rights.

The Gutenberg press revolutionised other sectors of the society as well. Martin Luther registered Protestant principles against Catholic guidelines. The writer of Utopia, Thomas More, stood strong against the oppressive emperor.

Mass media brought philosophical thoughts to the new heights, inspiring senior philosophers such as Jean Jacques Rousseau, and Georg Wilhelm Friedrich Hegel, who laid the modern concept of change. They became the source of inspiration for the latter days' philosophers as well as revolutionary leaders, who tried their hard to emancipate the people under the chain of slavery.

The indigenous people around the world fought for the rights and independence with the inspirations of mass media. As the wars were fought based on the philosophical guidelines and firm stance of leaders under the surveillance of the mass media, the colonial powers, tyrannical rules on the different parts of the world began crumbling. So, the rulers of today are well familiar with the power of the mass media.

The mass media developed some values and parameters to remain independence from the control of state and private power centres.

The gurus of mass media set rules requiring that the news, views, and opinions should be impartial and catered discharging responsibility to the public. Similarly, the news should cover cases of conflict and must arouse interest among the readers. So, a journalist, unless and until not instructed or warned to do otherwise, works keeping the above mentioned values in the mind and writes accordingly.

But, some shrewd rulers familiar with the power of the mass media try to use it to glorify their deeds and hide their misdeeds so as to prolong their rule. Harassing journalists, bribing them or manipulating content are some aberrations plaguing the media sector. An American philosopher Billings Learned Hand rightly says: "The hand that rules the press, radio, the screen, and the far-spread magazine rules the country."

Along with the change of time, media for disseminating news, views and opinions should also embrace emerging trend, without compromising the core values of journalism. So, no one should be allowed to control all forms of media. The present day media are committed to restoring their own dignity, so they give much priority to news contents concerning nation building rather than branding certain persons. If anybody wants to glorify his or her deeds s/he should contribute to the society constructively.

Motive Of '*Mission* 84' Under Scanner

Ritu Raj Subedi



Political parties act as a bridge between the people and government even though their elected representatives remain the part of executive wing. The political campaigns include mass rallies and meetings, public hearings and interactions with the grassroots people, and debate on the issues of public interest and policy. Generally, these activities take place before the election, the barometer of parties' popularity and strength. The political campaigns have different forms but their aim is to communicate with the people and articulate their message to the general public. Through these campaigns, the parties seek to expand their organisation and establish agenda through pithy and snappy slogans.

Recently, Nepali political parties have been engaged in a series of campaigns primarily intended to gain electoral advantage. However, the rationality of such political caravans has come under scanner. These campaigns are like hustings happening in less than a year after the three-tier polls were held last year. Four years are left for the next elections to be held. In multiparty system, it is not unnatural for the parties to launch the campaigns to push the future election agenda. But the foremost responsibility of the elected representatives is to fulfil pledge made before the voters.

Ownership dispute

However, there is a dispute on the ownership of the term 'mission 84.' Initially, Rastriya Swotantra Party (RSP) has coined it and started various programmes under its banner. The RSP has blown a fuse after the main opposition CPN-UML initiated 'mission 84' with a view to form a majority government after four years under its slogan 'Prosperous Nepal, Happy Nepali.' Worried by the UML's claims to patent on 'mission 84,' RSP chair Rabi Lamichhane has asked all 'old parties' to form a consensus government and utilise the remaining four years as the 'last opportunity' to 'correct' themselves and resolve all the critical problems facing the nation.

In an apparent reference to the UML, Lamichhane argued that other parties do not have right to talk about the 'mission 84.' "There are 'mission 80,' 'mission 81,' 'mission 82,' and 'mission 83.' Act jointly for the remaining four years for the cause of people," he told all mainstream parties. Rabi's party rose to national scene in the last general election, posing a formidable challenge to mainstream forces that lost to the RSP in the key urban areas. RSP's emergence has been seen as the failure of major parties in ensuring stability, good governance and effective service delivery to the people.

The government formed following the first three-tier polls held under the new constitution failed to complete its full term in office as the House of Representatives (HoR) was dissolved. The political instability coupled with a string of corruption scandals and cases of fraudulence frustrated the masses, breeding ground for the rise of new political forces. Akin to the logic of Lamichhane, Nepali Congress (NC) general secretary duo – Gagan Thapa and Bishwo Prakash Sharma - have insisted that they would not fret over the 'mission 84'. "We should worry about putting the nation on the right direction from 2081 B.S. to 2083 B.S.," they said.

> The elected representatives had better pay heed to present public plight while proving their mettle instead of singing an untimely tune of 'mission 84'.

Despite having a sweeping mandate, the then Nepal Communist Party (NCP)-led government under its chair KP Sharma Oli collapsed owing to the raging intra-party conflict. Oli dissolved the HoR twice, plunging the country into uncharted waters of volatility. The five-party coalition government constituted following the restoration of House muddled through and managed to let the legislature complete it full five year tenure. The second three-tier polls last year produced a hung parliament. With the previous alliance taking on the mantle of the government, the UML has to be satisfied with the opposition bench. In the elections, the parties got the jitters with the loss of the significant number of seats in federal and provincial parliaments.

And the UML's 'mission 84' that basically covered the mid-hill areas sought to check the influence of new parties. After losing in the cities, the UML is fearful that the wave of new parties might reach the mid-hill zone considered its strongholds. This is why the party is sloganeering the 'mission 84' right after the polls in 2079 B.S. It has claimed that the campaign has succeeded to control 'deviation' gripping the party functionaries. The mission intended to protect its support base and increase the new membership in view of its nationwide electoral loss.

Mettle

However, the observers think UML's campaign flunked in conveying a new message in the national politics though it connected the party to the grassroots. It concentrated on branding Oli, who was the sole speaker of all gatherings. Oli talked about bringing prosperity to the people but could not offer roadmap and outlook of development. He donned ethnic attires, played the musical instruments and enjoyed the local songs but did not raise the issues of economic and gender inequality, and deep-rooted caste discrimination and superstitions. Had he vigorously discussed these subjects with the locals, the mission could have been turned into an impactful social and political awareness drive.

The parties can go to the people at any time. But while talking about 'Mission 84,' they must not deflect the issues or questions to be raised in the coming four years which can be crucial to give a shape to the crisis-ridden economy and instil the confidence in the people. The electorates elect certain candidates or parties with a hope that the latter would address their problems and channel their concerns into legislation. The elected representatives had better pay heed to present public plight while proving their mettle instead of singing an untimely tune of 'mission 84'.

(The author is Deputy Executive Editor of this daily.)

Fighting Against Cancer Epidemics

Dr. Shyam P Lohani



Cancer, a formidable adversary, continues to plague societies worldwide, causing immense suffering and loss. The incidence of cancer is on the rise, posing a significant challenge to healthcare systems globally. The incidence of cancer cases has been steadily rising over the past few decades, posing a considerable challenge to the country's healthcare system. To address this growing crisis, urgent and comprehensive measures must be taken to contain and combat this devastating disease.

Around 9.6 million people died due to cancer in 2018 and it is the second leading cause of death worldwide and projected to increase by 70 per cent to 13.1 million annually by 2030. Globally, about 17 per cent of all deaths are attributed to cancer (WHO, 2018). Out of total deaths due to cancer, approximately 70 per cent occur in low and middle-income countries. In Nepal, around 7.7 per cent of total deaths were attributed to cancer in 2012 (WHO, 2014).

Contributing Factors

One of the primary reasons behind the surge in cancer cases in Nepal is the changing lifestyle patterns of its population. Urbanization, adoption of Western dietary habits, sedentary lifestyles, and increased tobacco and alcohol consumption have all contributed to the rise in cancer risk factors. Additionally, exposure to environmental pollutants, including air and water pollution, further exacerbates the problem.

Nepal faces a significant challenge in terms of cancer awareness and early detection. Many individuals lack knowledge about the signs and symptoms of cancer, leading to delayed diagnosis and treatment. Moreover, limited access to healthcare facilities, especially in rural areas, hampers early detection efforts. Public awareness campaigns and educational programmes are crucial to promoting early detection and improving survival rates.

Nepal's healthcare system is strained due to limited resources and infrastructure, which poses a significant obstacle in tackling the growing cancer burden. Insufficient funding, inadequate medical equipment, and a shortage of trained healthcare professionals make it challenging to provide timely and quality cancer care. The government must prioritise healthcare investment to strengthen the infrastructure and ensure accessible and affordable cancer treatment for all.

To combat the rising cancer incidence, Nepal urgently requires comprehensive cancer control programmes. These programs should focus on prevention, early detection, treatment, and palliative care. Implementing population-wide interventions, such as tobacco control measures, promoting healthy lifestyles, and providing vaccination against cancer-causing viruses like HPV, can significantly reduce cancer cases. Additionally, establishing cancer registries and strengthening cancer research can help in understanding the disease burden and tailoring effective interventions.

Addressing the cancer burden in Nepal requires collaboration between the government, healthcare professionals, NGOs, and international organizations. International support in terms of funding, expertise, and knowledge sharing can play a crucial role in strengthening Nepal's cancer care infrastructure. Collaborative efforts can lead to the development of effective strategies, capacity building, and improved access to affordable cancer treatments.

Global Efforts

It is important to enhance prevention and awareness programmes throughout the country. Prevention is undeniably the most effective strategy against cancer. Governments and healthcare organisations must prioritise public health campaigns that promote healthy lifestyles, raise awareness about risk factors, and encourage regular screenings. By empowering individuals with knowledge and preventive measures, we can reduce the incidence of cancer and save countless lives.

> By working together, we can pool resources, expertise, and experiences to develop effective strategies for cancer prevention, treatment, and survivorship.

Strengthening healthcare infrastructure is of paramount importance. The burden of cancer can be overwhelming for healthcare systems, particularly in low- and middle-income countries. Investing in healthcare infrastructure, including cancer treatment centres, diagnostic facilities, and skilled healthcare professionals, is crucial. Governments should allocate sufficient resources to ensure equitable access to quality cancer care, especially in underserved regions.

Advancements in cancer research and innovation have revolutionised treatment options and improved survival rates. Governments, academia, and private sectors should collaborate to increase funding for cancer research, focusing on early detection methods, targeted therapies, and personalised medicine. Sharing knowledge and resources globally will accelerate progress in understanding and combating this complex disease.

Therefore, affordable and accessible treatment facilities should be available despite financial abilities. Access to affordable cancer treatment is a fundamental right that should not be compromised. Governments must negotiate fair pricing with pharmaceutical companies to ensure the availability of life-saving medications at affordable rates. Additionally, efforts should be made to improve access to treatment in remote areas, reducing financial barriers and improving transportation networks for patients seeking care.

Cancer knows no borders, and neither should our fight against it. International collaboration and information sharing are vital to address the rising cancer incidence worldwide. Governments, healthcare organisations, and research institutions should establish platforms for sharing best practices, treatment protocols, and research findings. By working together, we can pool resources, expertise, and experiences to develop effective strategies for cancer prevention, treatment, and survivorship.

The increasing cancer incidence in Nepal demands immediate attention and action. By addressing the risk factors, improving awareness, strengthening healthcare infrastructure, and implementing comprehensive cancer control programmes, Nepal can effectively combat this growing public health crisis. The government, healthcare professionals, and the international community must work together to ensure that every Nepali citizen has access to timely diagnosis, quality treatment, and supportive care, ultimately reducing the burden of cancer in the country.

The rising incidence of cancer demands a collective effort from governments, healthcare organizations, researchers, and individuals worldwide. By prioritising prevention, strengthening healthcare infrastructure, investing in research, ensuring affordable treatment, and fostering global collaboration, we can make significant strides in reducing the burden of cancer. Let us unite in this fight, leaving no one behind, and strive for a future where cancer is no longer a global health crisis.

(Dr. Lohani is the executive director at the Health Concern, Nepal. lohanis@gmail.com)

50 YEARS AGO

THE RISING NEPAL

December 24, 1973

Fine

Janakpurdham, Dec. 23: The Dhanusha district administration has fined Ram Asis Pandey Rs. 25/- on the charge of indecent behaviour under alcoholic intoxication, reports RSS.

NOTICE TO CONTRIBUTORS

TRN welcomes articles, letters and comments from our valued readers and contributors.
Please email your contributions to:

trnfeatures@hotmail.com
trnfeatures@gmail.com

Or send them to
P.O. Box 23, Kathmandu, Nepal

READER'S MAIL

Milestone In Power Infrastructure

This is in reference to the news report "*PM inaugurates nation's second largest power substation*" published in this daily on Dec. 23. This good news surely serves to dispel some gloom from the hearts and minds of the people.

It is also a testament to the fact that some good things are happening in the country to lift the spirits of many people.

Over the last few years, the country is making significant strides in electricity sector, to the extent that it has started exporting electricity to neighbouring India.

The construction of this substation in Sunsari is another feather in the cap. This mammoth structure facilitates as well as addresses the challenges in production, distribution, consumption, and even export of electricity, the production of which is increasing with every passing year.



As we are seeing the explosive growth of electric vehicles on the roads, this electricity will surely power them, reducing the import of petrol and diesel, the import of which is draining our foreign exchange reserves. Good things are on the horizon!

Nikeesa Neupane
Kapan, Kathmandu

TAILPIECE

Kathy began a job as an elementary school counsellor and she was eager to help.

One day, during recess, Kathy noticed a young girl standing by herself on one side of the playing field while the rest of the kids were playing a game of soccer.

A while later, Kathy walked over to the young girl and offered, "Would you like me to be your friend?"

The girl looked at Kathy suspiciously, then said hesitantly, "Okay, I guess so..."

"Why are you standing here all alone?" asked Kathy.

"Because," the little girl said with great exasperation, "I'm the goalie!"

UN approves watered-down resolution on aid to Gaza

AP
United Nations, Dec. 23



PHOTO: AP

People gather during the Security Council meeting at United Nations headquarters, Friday, Dec. 22, 2023.

The U.N. Security Council adopted a watered-down resolution Friday calling for immediately speeding aid deliveries to hungry and desperate civilians in Gaza but without the original plea for an "urgent suspension of hostilities" between Israel and Hamas.

The long-delayed vote in the 15-member council was 13-0 with the United States and Russia abstaining. The U.S. abstention avoided a third American veto of a Gaza resolution following Hamas' surprise Oct. 7 attacks inside Israel. Russia wanted the stronger language restored; the U.S. did not.

Still, "It was the Christmas miracle we were all hoping for," said United Arab Emirates Ambassador Lana Nusseibeh, who sponsored the resolution. She said it would send a signal to the people in Gaza that the Security Council was working to alleviate their suffering.

The resolution culminated a week and a half of high-level diplomacy by the United States, the UAE on behalf of Arab nations and others. The vote, initially scheduled for Monday, was pushed back each day until Friday.

A relieved U.S. Ambassador Linda Thomas-Greenfield told the council, "This was tough, but we got there."

She said the vote bolsters efforts "to alleviate this humanitarian crisis, to get life-saving assistance into Gaza and to get hostages out of Gaza, to push for the protection of innocent civilians and humanitarian workers, and to work towards a lasting peace."

"It is hard to overstate how urgent this is," Thomas-Greenfield said. "This resolution speaks to the severity of this crisis, and it calls on us all to do more."

The vote came immediately after the United States vetoed a Russian amendment that would have restored the call to immediately suspend hostilities. That vote was 10 countries in favour, the U.S. against and four abstentions,

Russia's U.N. Ambassador Vassily Nebenzia called the resolution "entirely toothless" and accused the United States of "shameful, cynical and irresponsible conduct" and resorting to tactics "of gross pressure, blackmail and twisting arms."

He said the resolution "would essentially be giving the Israeli armed forces complete freedom of movement for the clearing of the Gaza Strip."

Russia would have vetoed it, he said, if it hadn't been supported by a number of Arab countries.

Thus the resolution was stripped of its key provision with teeth — the call for "the urgent suspension of hostilities to allow safe and unhindered humanitarian access, and for urgent steps towards a sustainable cessation of hostilities."

US court declines to fast-track Trump's case

AFP
New York, Dec. 23



PHOTO: AFP

Former US President and 2024 Republican Presidential hopeful Donald Trump walks off the stage after speaking at a Republican volunteer recruitment event on July 8, 2023.

The US Supreme Court declined on Friday to immediately hear former president Donald Trump's claim that he is immune from prosecution, potentially delaying his 2020 election interference trial. Special Counsel Jack Smith had asked the nation's highest court to take up the immunity case on an expedited basis, bypassing the federal court of appeals.

The Supreme Court, which has a 6-3 conservative majority, including three justices nominated by Trump, denied the request in a one-line order that did not provide any reason for the decision.

The 77-year-old Trump, the frontrunner for the 2024 Republican presidential nomination, is currently scheduled to go on trial on March 4, 2024 on charges of conspiring to overturn the November 2020 election won by Democrat Joe Biden.

Trump's lawyers have repeatedly sought to delay the trial until after next year's election, including with the claim that a former president enjoys "absolute immunity" and cannot be prosecuted for actions he took while in the White House. US District Judge Tanya Chutkan, who is to preside over Trump's March trial, rejected the immunity claim on December 1, saying a former president does not have a "lifelong 'get-out-of-jail-free' pass."

"Defendant's four-year service as Commander in Chief did not bestow on him the divine right of kings to evade the criminal accountability that governs his fellow citizens," she added.

Trump's lawyers appealed Chutkan's decision to the US Court of Appeals for the DC Circuit and Smith, the special counsel, asked the Supreme Court to step in and hear the case itself.

"This case presents a fundamental question at the heart of our democracy: whether a former President is absolutely immune from federal prosecution for crimes committed while in office," Smith said in a filing to the Supreme Court.

"It is of paramount public importance that respondent's claims of immunity be resolved as expeditiously as possible -- and, if respondent is not immune, that he receive a fair and speedy trial on these charges," he said.

Appeals court hearing on January 9

With the Supreme Court's rejection of Smith's request, the appeals court will now first hear the immunity case.

Carl Tobias, a law professor at the University of Richmond, said this could make it difficult to maintain the March trial date.

Tobias noted the Supreme Court had agreed to "fast-track" appeals in 19 cases over the past four years and it was unclear why the justices had declined to do so here.

Trump welcomed the Supreme Court's move and said he was looking forward to presenting his arguments before the appeals court.

Israeli strike kills 76 members in one Gaza family

AP
Gaza Strip, Dec. 23



PHOTO: AP

Family and friends of Israeli soldier Lt. Yaacov Elian mourn over his grave during his funeral at Kiryat Shaul cemetery in Tel Aviv, Israel, Friday, Dec. 22, 2023.

An Israeli airstrike killed 76 members of an extended family, rescue officials said Saturday, a day after the U.N. chief warned again that nowhere is safe in Gaza and that Israel's ongoing offensive is creating "massive obstacles" to the distribution of humanitarian aid.

Friday's strike on a building in Gaza City was among the deadliest of the Israel-Hamas war, now in its 12th week, said Mahmoud Bassal, a spokesman for Gaza's Civil Defence department. He provided a partial list of the names of those killed — 16 heads of households from the al-Mughrabi family — and said the dead included women and children.

Among the dead were Issam al-Mughrabi, a veteran employee of U.N. Development Program, his wife, and their five children.

"The loss of Issam and his family has deeply affected us all. The U.N. and civilians in Gaza are not a target," said Achim Steiner, the head of the agency. "This war must end."

Israel declared war after Hamas militants stormed across the border on Oct. 7, killing some 1,200 people and taking some 240 hostages. Israel has vowed to keep up the fight until Hamas is destroyed and removed from power in Gaza and all the hostages are freed.

More than 20,000 Palestinians have been killed in Israel's war to destroy Hamas and more than 53,000 have been wounded, according to health officials in Gaza, a besieged territory ruled by the Islamic militant group for the past 16 years.

Israel blames Hamas for the high civilian death toll, citing the group's use of crowded residential areas for military purposes and its tunnels under urban areas.

It has unleashed thousands of airstrikes since Oct. 7, and has largely refrained from commenting on specific attacks, including discussing the intended target.

Tunisians vote in local elections on Sunday

AP
Tunisia, Dec. 23

Butter and milk shortages. Political party boycotts. Ongoing prosecutions of the president's critics. This is the environment in which Tunisians will head to the polls on Sunday for the country's first local elections since President Kais Saied wrote a new constitution that voters approved last year.

Voting will determine the composition of a new National Council of Regions and Districts — one component of Saied's vision to reshape politics in Tunisia, the country that sparked the region-wide uprisings that became known as the Arab Spring 12 years ago. The new legislative chamber is designed to focus on economic development and candidates have campaigned on the radio about building schools, roads and other infrastructure.

It harkens back to Saied's campaign promise to distribute power and funds far from Tunisia's capital. Tunis is synonymous with widely criticized government bureaucracy whose unpopularity helped fuel Saied's rise.

But despite the transformation promised, few signs of enthusiasm about elections and their ability to buoy Tunisia are apparent. In the 13th election since the 2011 revolution, there's little understanding about the stakes, what the new chamber has the power to do and whether voting even matters. "People used to be motivated in other elections but nobody talks about this one or is up to date," said Najib, a cafe owner in La Goulette who said in past contests candidates regularly put up signs throughout his establishment. He declined to give his name out of fear of losing customers.

Such is a familiar story for Tunisia, a country plagued by high unemployment, drought and shortages of basic necessities that credit ratings firms say is teetering on the verge of bankruptcy.

Amid a similar lack of enthusiasm, barely 11% of voters turned out for parliamentary elections last year even with growing concerns about the country's political and economic woes.

Tunisia recently passed a new budget without major reforms that could bolster the economy or lure foreign lenders. It retains price controls and subsidies for flour, electricity and fuel. That's even though reducing government spending on subsidies is one reform that the IMF has demanded in exchange for a $1.9 billion loan.

"The government is not living up to its responsibilities with regard to subsidies, which explains the scarcity of products," said Aram Belhadj, a professor at the School of Economy and Management of Tunis. Though the subsidies are written into the budget, Tunisia's recent pattern of not compensating vendors has exacerbated shortages for goods like baguettes, he added. Despite political apathy, he noted that amid the shortages, people had begun paying closer attention to budgetary matters.

PRISM

Mysterious metal seats on N.J. beach

New Jersey: A set of rusted-out metal seats that washed up on a New Jersey beach probably came loose from a railcar used to make an artificial reef, police said. Local resident Matthew Perry posted a series of videos to TikTok showing the row of four rusted-out seats he found on a beach in Margate.

Jacob theorized they might have been airplane seats from a crash, but the Margate Police Department said they appear to have a far less tragic origin. "The seats are far too heavy to have come from anything like a plane," Margate Police Chief Matthew Hankinson told NJ.com.

Wildlife experts 'stumped' by bear cub

Arizona: Wildlife experts in Arizona said they are "stumped" by an abnormally small bear cub that weighs just 15 pounds at nearly a year old, but seems perfectly healthy.

Bearizona Wildlife Park said on social media that the cub was rescued from a Tucson neighborhood last week, but experts at the park and Arizona Game and Fish were shocked by the bear's small size. The little bear weighs just 15 pounds, despite being nearly a year old.

"Bear cubs in the United States are all born close to January or February, so this little fella should be around 70 pounds this time of year," Dave O'Connell, Bearizona's chief operating officer, said in a news release.

(AP)

'Flu and COVID infections are rising and could get worse in US'

AP
New York, Dec. 23

Look for flu and COVID-19 infections to ramp up in the coming weeks, U.S. health officials say, with increases fuelled by holiday gatherings, too many unvaccinated people and a new version of the coronavirus that may be spreading more easily. High levels of flu-like illnesses were reported last week in 17 states — up from 14 the week before, the Centres for Disease Control and Prevention said Friday.

"Folks are traveling a lot more this season. They want to see their families," said the CDC's Dr. Manisha Patel. "And all of that sort of adds to the mix" in the spread of viruses.

Health officials are keeping an eye on a version of the ever-evolving coronavirus, known as JN.1. The omicron variant was first detected in the U.S. in September and now accounts for an estimated 20% of cases. The CDC expects it to reach 50% in the next two weeks, Patel said.

It may spread easier or be better at evading our immune systems, but there is no evidence that the strain causes more severe disease than other recent variants, health officials say. And current evidence indicates vaccines and antiviral medications work against it.

As for flu, early signs suggest current vaccines are well-matched to the strain that is causing the most illnesses, and that strain usually doesn't cause as many deaths and hospitalizations as some other versions.

But the bad news is vaccinations are down this year, officials say. About 42% of U.S. adults had gotten flu shots by the first week of December, down from about 45% at the same time last year, according to the CDC.

Americans have also been slow to get other vaccinations. Only about 18% have gotten an updated COVID-19 shot that became available in September. At nursing homes, about a third of residents are up to date with COVID-19 vaccines.

And only 17% of adults 60 and older had received new shots against another respiratory virus. RSV, respiratory syncytial virus, is a common cause of mild coldlike symptoms but it can be dangerous for infants and older people.

The CDC last week took the unusual step of sending a health alert to U.S. doctors urging them to immunize their patients against the trio of viruses.

The Carolinas are currently seeing the heaviest traffic for respiratory infections in emergency rooms, according to CDC data posted this week.

It's not as dire as some past winters, but some patients are still waiting days to get a hospital bed, noted Dr. Scott Curry, an infectious diseases specialist at the Medical University of South Carolina in Charleston.

"We've barely been cold in South Carolina, and flu tends to hit us very hard when people actually get some cold weather to deal with," he said. "We could get worse, very easily, in the next four to eight weeks."



PHOTO: AP

A flu vaccine is readied at the L.A. Care and Blue Shield of California Promise Health Plans' Community Resource Centre in Lynwood, Calif., on Friday, Oct. 28, 2022.

TODAY IN HISTORY

1929 – A four alarm fire breaks out in the West Wing of the White House in Washington, D.C.
1951 – Libya becomes independent. Idris I is proclaimed King of Libya.
1952 – First flight of Britain's Handley Page Victor strategic bomber.
1969 – Nigerian troops capture Umuahia, the Biafran capital.
1971 – LANSA Flight 508 is struck by lightning and crashes in the Puerto Inca District in the Department of Huánuco in Peru, killing 91.
1974 – Cyclone Tracy devastates Darwin, Australia.
1999 – Indian Airlines Flight 814 is hijacked in Indian airspace between Kathmandu, Nepal, and Delhi, India. The aircraft landed at Kandahar in Afghanistan. The incident ended on December 31 with the release of 190 survivors (one passenger is killed).
2018 – A helicopter crash kills Martha Érika Alonso, first female Governor of Puebla, Mexico, and her husband Rafael Moreno Valle Rosas, former governor.

CLOUDY WEATHER TO CLEAR FROM MONDAY

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 23

The Meteorological Forecasting Division has forecasted that the current cloud situation will improve from Monday across the country.

The country has a partial impact of the western system, so the weather will improve from the western part and gradually move towards the eastern part. The improvement is expected to begin from Sunday evening in the western parts of the country, it said.

Sanjeev Adhikari, a senior meteorologist at the Division, said that there was less chance of rainfall across the country, butthe high Himalayan regions of Gandaki, Koshi, Karni, Sudhurpaschim and Bagmati Provinces could receive snowfall.

In the hilly regions of Sudurpashchim and Karnali provinces, there is a possibility of light rainfall in one or two places.



PHOTO: RSS

The construction of a Thuli Bheri bridge linking Nalgaad Municipality of Jajarkot district and Aathbiskot Municipality of Rukum West being delayed after it broke down in last April.

'Federal Education Act is in top priority'

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 23

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has said that the School Education Act, which is under consideration in the Parliament, is in the top priority of the government.

Addressing a programmme organised by the Unified All Nepal Teacher's Association in Kathmandu on Saturday, Prime Minister Prachanda said so.

He said, "Many of you are eager about the Federal Education Act. Our immediate focus, once the new session commences, will be to pass both the Truth and Reconciliation Act and the Federal Education Act. The education act is the utmost priority for the government."

"Teachers have exerted pressure from the streets to address their demands, and this has helped the government," he said.

The Prime Minister assured, "From the suggestions provided in the current draft, the reasonable and feasible demands will be addressed."

Meanwhile, Prime Minister Prachanda said load-shedding has ended in the Kathmandu Valley during his second term and informed his plan to light up the entire country during his third term.

Inaugurating the city assembly of Budanilkantha Municipal committee of the CPN (Maoist Centre), Prime Minister Prachanda said that despite the significant achievements made by the party during his tenure, the credit for those accomplishments was often attributed to others.

"Amidst the various works of development and prosperity in the country, pivotal strides were accomplished during our tenure. Throughout my three terms in leadership, we've executed strategically significant initiatives," he added.

The Prime Minister said despite the significant achievements made during his three tenures, he could not claim the ownership for those accomplishments.

Japan Cabinet OKs record military budget to speed up strike capability, eases lethal arms export ban

AP
Tokyo Dec. 23

Japan's Cabinet on Friday approved a hefty 16% increase in military spending next year and eased its postwar ban on lethal weapons exports, underscoring a shift away from the country's self-defense-only principle.

The moves came as Japan accelerates the deployment of long-range cruise missiles that can hit targets in China or North Korea while Japanese troops increasingly work with allies and take on more offensive roles.

In a latest step under a new security strategy that Japan adopted a year ago, Prime Minister Fumio Kishida's government also allowed the export of weapons and components made in Japan under foreign licenses to the licensing nations. The controversial move is the first major revision of Japan's arms export ban since an earlier easing in 2014.

"In taking the action, we hope to contribute to defend a free and open international order based on the rule of law and to achieve the peace and stability in the Indo-Pacific region," Kishida told reporters. "There is no change to our principle as a pacifist nation."

The government quickly approved the first export shipment under the change, agreeing to send to the United States surface-to-air Patriot guided missiles produced in Japan under an American license. Officials said it would complement U.S. stock, raising speculation that Japanese-produced Patriots may be sent to Ukraine.

The easing also paves the way for future possible exports to the U.S., Britain and six European licensing nations involving dozens of lethal weapons and components, including F-15s and fighter jet engines.

"The scope, scale, and speed of Japan's security reforms have been unprecedented," U.S. Ambassador Rahm Emanuel said in a statement on X. He praised the easing of the defense equipment and transfer policy as historic and "a significant example of Japan's shared commitment to deterrence."

The ban on the export of lethal weapons has limited the scope of Japan's efforts to develop arms technology and equipment. The easing would help strengthen Japan's feeble defense industry and broaden the country's new official military aid designed for like-minded nations in the Indo-Pacific region in countering Chinese assertiveness, experts say.

Japan is spending more than 70 billion yen ($490 million) in 2024 for the development of a next-generation fighter jet with Britain and Italy, and the project hinges on a futher easing of restrictions to allow the export of jointly developed lethal weapons to third countries — a change Kishida wants by the end of February.

Cuban government defends plans to either cut rations or increase prices

AP
Havana Dec. 23

The Cuban government said Friday it will have to either increase prices for fuel and electricity, or reduce rations for basic supplies. President Miguel Díaz-Canel said such difficult measures were needed for difficult times, after the minister of the economy said Cuba's economy contracted between 1% and 2% this year, and inflation ran at about 30%. There were problems in the tourism industry — Cuba's main source of income — and in farm production.

"This is a question of complicated measures, as complicated as are these times," Díaz-Canel said. "I emphatically deny that this is neo-liberal plan against the people, nor a crusade against small businesses, nor an elimination of the basic market basket" that Cubans can get with government coupons.

Prime Minister Manuel Marrero Cruz said that because of economic problems, the government will have to raise prices for gasoline, electricity and gas, or reduce the amount of food and other basics contained in government ration books. The remarks came in appearances at the closing sessions of Cuba's National Assembly of People's Power, effectively Cuba's congress.

The economic crisis in Cuba has already pushed hundreds of thousands of people to leave in a bid to reach the United States. Long lines at gasoline stations had gotten shorter recently, but the news of possible price increases could prompt a rush to fill up.

"Since they spoke (in congress), I haven't been able to get gas yet," Alberto Corujo, a 54-year-old driver, said as he waited in a long line at a gas station in Havana.

Mercy García, a secretary at a state-owned business, said times were indeed tough.

Once successful in...

Climate Change (UNFCCC), the Clean Development Mechanism (CDM), defined in Article 12 of the Protocol, allows a country with an emission-reduction or emission-limitation commitment under the Kyoto Protocol to implement an emission-reduction project in the developing countries. Such projects can earn saleable certified emission reduction (CER) credits, each equivalent to one tonne of CO2, which can be counted towards meeting Kyoto targets.

According to him, there is a potential of 1 million domestic bio-gas plants in Nepal, but the government should increase the subsidy amount and support in the maintenance of the plants. However, past studies had estimated the national potential for biogas plants in Nepal at 1.9 million. They also suggested that the government subsidy was the major factor behind the success of the bio-gas programme. This fact was supported by the AEPC's statement in 2021 that the demand in bio-gas plant has going down.

Biogas versus LP gas

The country is spending a large amount of foreign currency in importing the LP gas. According to the statistics of the Department of Customs, LP gas import has increased by over 100 per cent in the last five years. In the Fiscal Year 2017/19, Nepal imported LP gas worth Rs. 27.13 billion while in 2022/23, it imported the gas worth Rs. 58.15 billion,

The country has imported LPG worth Rs. 15.4 billion the first four months (mid-July to mid-November) of the current fiscal year. Increased use of biogas means reduction in the imports of petroleum products and saving of the foreign exchange.

Meanwhile, the latest Census of 2021 revealed that about three-fourth of the households in Nepal still use firewood or bio-fuel to cook their meal which has its repercussions on health and environment. The promotion and use of bio-gas and improved cook stoves had significantly improved the health of women and children in the rural areas.

"Along with the biogas installation, the situation of health and sanitation is being gradually enhanced; deforestation (for the cause of firewood) is being curbed in Nepal. The technology is being concerned on caste and ethnicity, gender etc. issues to make the sector more inclusive, participative, decentralised and balanced," the AEPC said in one of its report.

A biogas plant can be run with animal dung, human excreta and the natural materials that decay, and the byproduct of the biogas plant is natural fertiliser. According to Subedi of NBPA, bio-gas is a model project of Nepal that uses all Nepali materials in construction, is carbon-neutral, healthy and economically beneficial.

"You can imagine its contributions to the economy from the fact that it has replaced about 5 million LPG cylinders. But our politicians as well as the bureaucracy seem indifferent to this," he said. Replacing 5 million cylinders mean saving about Rs. 10 billion.

The AEPC also said that any development in domestic energy would contribute to the nation development by reducing import, biogas technology is one of the reliable alternative energy sources used for cooking and lighting. Accordingly, national biogas programme has been considered one of the most successful programmes in Nepal.

Tarai features more bio-gas plants

Bio-gas programme is well received in the Tarai region and eight of 10 districts having highest number of plants are in this region. Kailali has the highest number of domestic bio-gas – 30,874 plants, followed by Makwanpur 29,525 and Jhapa 27,358. Humla, Dolpa and Jumla districts have only two, four and six plants respectively while Manang is the only district having no bio-gas plant.

However, Sunsari is the district that has highest number of large bio-gas plants with 50 projects in operation. Morang, Kaski and Jhapa have 41, 40 and 34 large biogas plants respectively.

According to the AEPC, at least 40 districts have the large biogas plants.

There are two types of bio-gas plants – large and domestic. Any bio-gas plant that has the capacity of 2-12 cubic metres is considered domestic and plant above 12.5 cubic metres is large.

Meanwhile, some municipalities have developed biogas plants above 100-cubic metre capacity. AEPC's Executive Director Dhakal informed that a bio-gas plant with a capacity 5,500 cubic metres is constructed in Dumkibas of Nawalparasi West.

Biogas is produced by anaerobic digestion or fermentation or decomposition of organic wastes by the action of methanogenic bacteria, according to AEPC. During digestion about 25-30 per cent of the dry matter of waste is converted into a combustible gas and residue of 70-75 per cent of the total solids content comes out as sludge which is known as slurry. Once dried, this slurry is used as the compost manure.

A new technology

Meanwhile, our Reporter in Hile of Dhankuta district, said that about 100 families in Dhankuta Municipality have replaced LP gas cylinder with an Israeli technology that uses a portable dome with a digester which is easy to install and operate. Excited by the success of the new technology and attraction in the rural areas of the municipality, the local government is planning to expand this facility to 5,000 households. The plant is being installed with the municipal subsidy of Rs. 40,000, household's contribution of Rs. 16,000 and supplier's contribution of Rs. 20,000. About 5-10 kg of manure is enough to create gas to cook three-time meals for a family.

Govt has prioritised good...

There had been significant changes in IT and ICT sectors, Minister Sharma said, adding that they were working to update Nepal's laws to keep up with these developments. She said that a new policy would be introduced to monitor new media through the Media Council Bill. She said that laws should be amended since new media was also developing as online media and it was necessary to regulate and manage it.

On the occasion, senior journalist Harsha Subba along with local journalists submitted a memorandum to Minister Sharma demanding formation of a Journalist Academy.

Meanwhile, inaugurating the Information Highway Optical Fiber Network at Hile Exchange Centre in Dhankuta under Koshi section of mid-hill Highway, Minister Sharma stressed the need of digitalization for development and digital infrastructure for digitalization. She said that investment in digital infrastructure must be increased for the rapid development of the country.

The information highway in the Koshi section is now operational with Nepal Telecom laying the optical fibers over 683 kilometers' stretch of road, funded by the Rural Telecommunication Development Fund of the Nepal Telecommunications Authority. The highway allows any internet service provider company to expand its services.

Minister Sharma said that the project would be extended to all sections of the Mid-Hill Highway. She mentioned that the Mid-Hill Highway, was a gift to the Republic of Nepal. She expressed confidence that the information highway would connect the residents of the Mid-Hill region to the main flow of telecommunications.

She said that the government had given high priority to the development and use of information technology. She said that telecommunication was the basic infrastructure of information technology. Stating that the expansion of fiber to the home (FTTH) services based on optical fiber had been emphasised, she said, "The government has expanded services to Taplejung, Bajhang, Bajura, Rukum West, Jumla and Kalikot this year. So far, 73 districts have been connected with FTTH."

Informing that the 4G service of the Nepal Telecom has been extended to 739 local levels covering 67 per cent of the country's total area, Minister Sharma stressed the need for expanding it to 100 per cent of the areas.

Biratnagar is centre of political...

He also congratulated all democratic figures, leaders, industrialists and journalists honoured on the occasion.

The President pointed out the need of stopping the brain drain by imparting training to human resources in the country and producing capable human resources with the expansion of industries related to agriculture, forest and minerals. The Head of the State asked the industrialists and businessmen to create such environment in the country. Sharing the government alone could not make the country self-reliant, create employment, and promote export so as to end poverty, the President mentioned that it was possible only when the government collaborates with the private sector and it was necessary to make public private partnership more effective.

The President said the incumbent government would formulate new policy and act by taking into confidence private sector and holding broader consultation.

It is necessary to move ahead with robust collaboration among federal, province, and local levels and private sector for environment conservation as well as green and resilient economy and sustainable development.

President Paudel opined various shrines in the Koshi Province such as Halesi Mahadev, Tyamke's Sidda Baba, Pathivara Devi, Chintang Devi, Baraha Kshetra and stupas, temples and Lovarkati Kirat temple could be developed as attractive tourism destinations so that national economy could be contributed.

"This region has tremendous potential both in tourism or industrial aspects. All we need is a strong determination, commitment, honesty and morality," he asserted.

Wishing for the successful tenure of the team of establishment leadership, the Head of the State wished for the good health and longevity of all those feted on Saturday.

Similarly, Koshi Province Chief Parshuram Khapung said that the State should pay heed to the problems facing entrepreneurs of the private sector.

Chief Minister of Koshi Province, Kedar Karki, emphasised State's role to address need and aspirations of the public.

Nepali Congress' central committee member Bijaya Kumar Gachchhadar acknowledged the President as someone who long struggled for democracy and republic and urged him to play the role of a guardian to safeguard the federal democratic republic.

In the programme presided over by Bhim Ghimire, President of the Confederation of Nepalese Industries (CNI), former Chief Minister of Koshi Province, Hikmat Kumar Karki and CNI's Founder President Binod Kumar Chaudhary among others put forth their views. Altogether 29 personalities including freedom fighter, entrepreneurs and journalists duo Shankhar Kharel and Ananta Neupane were honoured in the event.

CNI, on the occasion, feted President Paudel.

Czech Republic holds a national day of mourning for the victims of its worst mass killing

AP
Prague Dec. 23

The Czech Republic came to a standstill at noon Saturday as people across the country observed a minute of silence as part of a national day of mourning to honor the victims of the worst mass killing in Czech history.

National flags on public buildings were at half-staff and bells tolled at noon. A Mass at St. Vitus cathedral in Prague, the biggest in the country, was celebrated for the victims. President Petr Pavel and speakers of both houses of Parliament attended the service that was open to everyone.

"We're all still in a shock in our own ways," Prague archbishop Jan Graubner said. "We need to clearly condemn what happened but we also need to look into the future."

"Nobody should be left alone in these tough moments," Charles University rector Milena Kralickova said in her remarks toward the end of the Mass. The shooting inside the university's Faculty of Arts on Thursday killed 14 people.

Similar religious services were held in other cities and towns, while Christmas markets in a number of places were closed or reduced their programs amid boosted security measures.

The shooting in the university at the heart of the Czech capital also wounded 25 people before the gunman killed himself. Police and prosecutors said they have evidence the 24-year-old shooter also killed his father earlier in the day and a man and a baby in Prague last week.

A sea of candles was shining at an impromptu memorial for the victims created in front of the university headquarters.

"It's been a horrible experience for us all but it still can't be compared with what the victims had to experience at the time of the attack and what their dear ones have to experience now," said Milos Vystrcil, speaker of Parliament's upper house, the Senate, one of those who came to light a candle.

"I think that to help them at this point we express our support and that's what we're all doing now."

The names of the 14 people who died are slowly being released. The university confirmed two staff members were among them, including the head of the Institute of Music Sciences, Lenka Hlávková. First-year student Lucie Spindlerova was another, said the Lidove noviny daily, where she also worked.

The shooter was Czech and a student at the Faculty of Arts. Investigators do not suspect a link to any extremist ideology or groups. Officials said they believed he acted alone. His motive is not yet clear.

Previously, the nation's worst mass shooting was in 2015, when a gunman opened fire in the southeastern town of Uhersky Brod, killing eight before fatally shooting himself.

We are still in transitional...

"I pay respect to such leaders and workers," he said. He said victory and defeat in the party was natural and the losers should cooperate with the winners.

"At present situation, reconciliation between friends is a must. The competition could have been in the general convention and one could have won and the other could have suffered a defeat. It is not that winners of today will win tomorrow or always," he said.

He said it would help for reconciliation in the party if the losers cooperated with the winners and the winners took help from the defeated friends," he said.

NC general secretary Bishwo Prakash Sharma said his party would picket the Singha Durbar if the government delayed in giving the rights to the provinces. He urged the government to formulate laws related to right delegation to province within three months.

NC leader and Member of the House of Representatives, Pradeep Paudel, said there was no need to change the electoral system to secure a two thirds majority for any party.

Despite changing electoral system, the parties themselves need to change their working style, he said.

Representatives of 13 districts are participating in the two-day conference, The agenda of the conference are federalism, secularism and a proportional electoral system. In the conference, coordination and co-work among the three-level governments for their rights and implementation of programmes will also be discussed.

About 800 representatives from the federal parliament constituencies, province assembly constituencies, municipalities and others are participating in the conference.

KVHC Quartet Strangle Launches Third Album

BY MANNU SHAHI



Strangle is a hardcore quartet based in Lalitpur devoted to refining their musicianship and self-expression through angry loud music for over a decade now.

Although the group started out as a thrash metal outfit, 'Strangle' eventually shifted into hardcore/crossover thrash and the members have been continuously developing their sonic palette in this genre.

Formed in 2009, the band performed at various outlets across Kathmandu and hustled in the valley's DIY punk scene till 2014. After that, many of the active members then moved abroad for higher education. This edition of the band also put out a demo in 2012.

After a two-year hiatus, the group reformed in 2016 with a new line-up and recorded their debut official publication: the 15-track album 'You're Next In Line' (2017). This was followed by their second entry EP 'The Illusion' (2018), and their sophomore album 'Nation Failed' (2020).

However, a few numbers from the eight song EP are repeated on their follow-up 13-track sophomore entry.

The present stack of members comprises Ashish Kayastha on guitars, Dipesh Joshi on drums, Bibek Tamang on bass and Santosh Shrestha on vocals. However, past band members included Utsav Thapa (vocals), Avinash Magar (drums), Ramesh Sunar (bass), Bikrant Singh Thapa (drums), Dipesh Gurung (drums) and Amrit Bhandari (vocals).

On December 16 this year, the quartet released their seven-track self-titled third album at the Purple Haze Rock Bar in Kathmandu. The official collection of songs is available for purchase at their bandcamp handle.

The album's launch featured the opening act by fellow Kathmandu Valley Hardcore (KVHC) associate Nainsook,. Both the groups presented astounding original sets, commencing a giant mosh pit beside the stage. The nearly 200 individuals in the audience were vibrantly applauding, head-banging and trying their best to reciprocate the energy emanating from the musicians dominating the venue. It was a splendid celebration of Kathmandu's hardcore and punk culture presented as a part of Purple Haze Underground series.

The launched album starts with 'Sinking Ship,' a crossover punk tune, the only song in the album to feature a guitar solo by ax-man Ashish. The second track 'Dud Bhaat' is reminiscent of the band's older materials; the fast paced first section is contrasted well by the halftime break down in the latter-half. The third song 'Sab Jhuto', my personal favorite, is a sludgy punk tune that executes odd meters and complementing rhythmic subdivisions.

The hardcore tune 'Passion Kills' is the only single to have a music video. The video was released on December 11 via Strangle's official YouTube channel. The vulnerable tune presents the narrative of an individual "giving everything for their passion, sustaining without any returns and getting hurt in the process."

The video, created by Kush in collaboration with Laltin Studio, features karate champion Akira Gurung, artist Sanish Kumar Shakya and skater Anup Shrestha along with the band. All of them represent their specific mediums of discipline and continuous dedication to honing their craft.

The fifth tune 'Striving To Stay' is an angry hardcore track comprising the most progressive structure in the collection with multiple transitions, breaks and build-up sections. The sixth tune 'Malai Jeuna Deu' starts with a pop-punk-like-riff but abruptly shifts to the signature Strangle flavour. The double tempo palm mute around the midsection elevates the whole arrangement giving room for drummer Dipesh to shine with his garnishing chops. The album concludes with the thrash metal influenced number 'Heaven' that perfectly sums up the entire experience.

Banksy stop sign taken from London street soon after it appears



AP
London, Dec. 23

The elusive artist Banksy displayed his latest work on a London street corner and it was taken less than hour after he confirmed its installation Friday.

A red stop sign with three military drones on it was taken in the middle of the day by a man with bolt cutters as witnesses snapped photos and shot video in the Peckham section of south London.

People commenting on Banksy's Instagram accurately predicted it wouldn't be there long after the artist posted a photo of it. Some of his work has sold for tens of millions of dollars.

"I went there thinking that people want that, I wanted to see it before something happened to it," a man who only wanted to be known as Alex told the Press Association.

He was among the many onlookers who watched in awe as a man in a red and black jacket climbed up on a bike next to the post where the sign was bolted to and began hitting it with his hands.

"We said, 'What are you doing?' but no one really knew what to do, we sort of just watched it happen," Alex said. "We were all a bit bemused; there was some honking of car horns."

The man then left and returned a few minutes later with bolt cutters to finish the job. Another man stabilized the Lime rental bike he stood on and he then removed it and ran away.

Banksy's thought-provoking street art is often seen as making a political statement. His Instagram followers widely interpreted his latest work as calling for a cease-fire in the Gaza Strip.

Charlie Sheen's neighbour arrested after being accused of assaulting actor



AP
Los Angeles, Dec. 23

Charlie Sheen's neighbour was arrested after being accused of assaulting the actor in a Malibu, California, home this week. Electra Schrock was arrested for assault with a deadly weapon, the Los Angeles County Sheriff's Department said in a statement Friday. She was also taken into custody for force likely to create bodily injury and burglary.

Authorities arrived at the residence Wednesday afternoon after receiving a battery-disturbance call.

Schrock, 47, was expected to appear in court Friday.

Representatives for Sheen did not immediately respond to a request for comment. Sheen, 58, is known for his role on 'Two and a Half Men.' He starred in films including 'Wall Street,' 'The Three Musketeers' and 'Major League.'

Radha: Fantasy around heritage, heritage within fantasy

BY AASHISH MISHRA
Kathmandu, Dec. 23

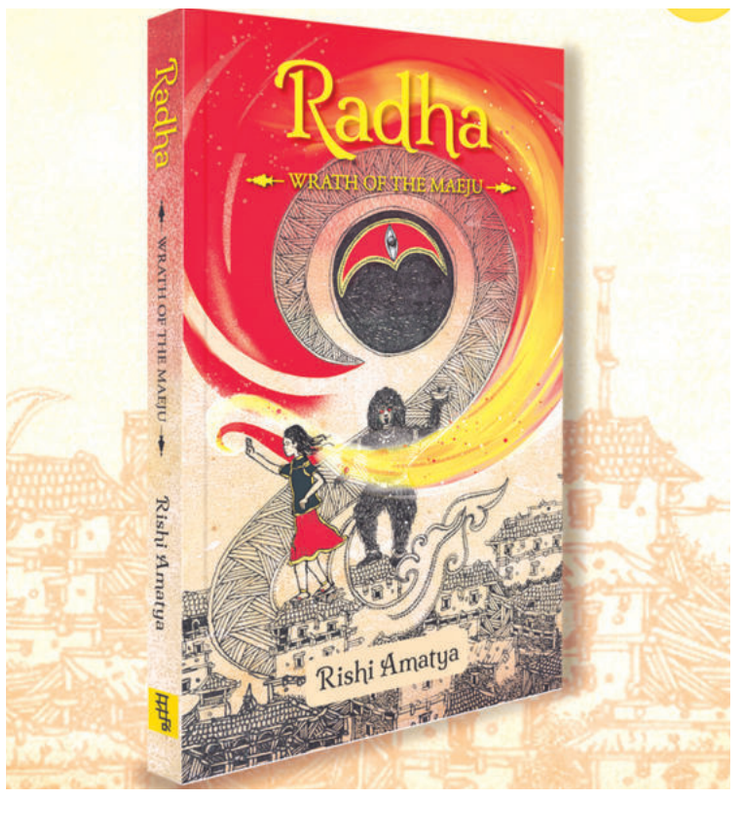
Predominantly, stories crafted for young adults share certain thematic consistencies – a young protagonist reluctantly taking up responsibilities beyond their age; characters exploring their identities, questioning who they are and where they belong; parental figures, or a lack thereof, and their influence on the protagonist; and metaphorical presentation of real-world challenges.

As a young adult fantasy, Rishi Amatya's debut novel 'Radha' also expectedly aligns itself with the genre's motifs. But it still succeeds in delivering a fresh tale through the skilful weaving of the ordinary with the extraordinary, of life with legend, of history with story and of divinity with humanity. 'Radha' is unique in that it bases itself on the physical and metaphysical elements of Patan Durbar Square and uses the rich mythos of the Nepal Mandal to infuse new flavour into familiar thematic threads.

'Radha,' unsurprisingly, has a girl named Radha as the main character. A newly retired Kumari, she now desires an ordinary life away from the office of the living goddess. She wants to help her mother Gyani Maya around the house, play with her brother Dhiraj and have her uncle Pradip give her tours of Mangal Bazaar. But the catastrophic earthquake of April 25, 2015, which not only shatters the physical structures around her but also unravels the fabric of her reality, forces her to put her desire for normalcy on hold. This cataclysm becomes the backdrop of a tale of cosmic proportions, where personal and supernatural forces collide, and Radha is propelled into a quest of self-discovery and understanding of what it truly means to be a god.

One of its strengths is that 'Radha' seamlessly blends fact with fiction and heritage with mysticism. Readers who follow Radha's adventures around Amatya's imagined Patan Durbar Square get to learn of the origins and significance of some of the monuments at the real Patan Durbar Square. In that sense, 'Radha' tricks people into learning history.

Another strength is that it does not box in its characters within specific ethnicities. The use of Nepal Bhasa and the Patan setting implies that Radha, Dhiraj, Pradip and others featured in the story are from the Newa community. But there is nothing beyond that to tie the personas to particular groups or lineages. The author does not give them last names. Their first names, too, are not overtly ethnic (Radha, Dhiraj, Pradip, Hari and Amogh are generic Nepali names).



Having said this, 'Radha' is rooted in Patan. The tale cannot stay the same if the location is changed. And this both enriches and limits it.

The care that Amatya takes in crafting Mangal Bazaar draws in readers and immerses them in the tapestry of its temples, caves, courtyards and, of course, the Kartik Dabu. But this requires the readers to have at least a passing familiarity with the Patan Durbar Square. This reporter asked three of his friends from outside the Kathmandu Valley to read the book and they said that they found it disorienting. They could not grasp where the Mani Gufa or the Bhimsen Temple was. The sequences in the Mul Chowk were not as impactful as they could have been because they could not place where the Chowk was. Perhaps a few paragraphs or a chapter to set the scene would have been useful.

Divided into seven chapters – from the Nepali months of Baisakh to Kartik – it is an easy read. Although the book jumps from one storyline to another, it does so without confusing the reader. The language is simple and does not require the use of a dictionary. The meanings of non-English words have been sufficiently clarified. The editor perhaps deserves more credit for this than the writer.

In conclusion, although not without flaws, Amatya's exploration of familial bonds, self-discovery, and the cosmic forces that shape our destinies make 'Radha' a captivating and relatable read. Amatya, who is a heritage interpreter, plays to his strengths and interprets Patan's lore into an engaging novel.

HOROSCOPE

tarot.com

ARIES: Rest assured that you know best. Your intuition may seem stronger and louder than usual, and you could have an important epiphany or two, possibly related to your work or other goals.

TAURUS: Your support systems can boost you up in the world. Friends or other acquaintances could prove especially helpful right now. Your membership to a special club or other group could come in handy.

GEMINI: It's time to be rewarded for all your efforts. All your time and dedication will pay off with a nice bonus of one kind or another. If you've been giving it your all, you could finally see some wonderful results.

CANCER: One person is all it takes to change your perspective. It's likely that a partner or other close friend will be the catalyst for a new experience that opens your eyes up to possibility.

LEO: It's not your imagination if everything feels more intense. You may feel like you're being put through the ringer for someone else's kicks, but rest assured: this will actually work out in your favour.

VIRGO: It's tempting to throw caution to the wind. Life seems free and easy, but you could be pinning a bit too much of your pleasure on one particular person. Don't let someone have too much sway over your own satisfaction.

LIBRA: Getting organised is easy when you put your mind to it. You will have the energy to be your most efficient self, checking off one thing after another on your to-do list.

SCORPIO: Creativity and productivity can be one and the same. You will be able to channel your buzziest ideas into something that can withstand the test of time.

SAGITTARIUS: Spending may be required today. A bill or debt could require you to pay up, perhaps directly to a relative or possibly on their behalf. However, you could also make some wise investments in your own space.

CAPRICORN: Your words carry extra weight right now. This is the time for you to have important conversations or finalise deals that need to be hammered out. You should be able to present your views with uncommon clarity.

AQUARIUS: Your daydreams are not worthless. It's easy for your mind to wander but those wanderings could lead you to a very financially viable idea. You never know what you'll come up with until you allow yourself to try.

PISCES: Self-control isn't a dirty word. There's a fine line between being mature and being too serious or controlling, so make sure you aren't overdoing it in the pursuit of being your best self.

CARTOON

gocomics.com





Kathmandu qualifies for playoffs with Lalitpur, Dhangadhi and Pokhara

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 23

Title-defender Kathmandu Rayzrs FC (KRFC) has kept its chance to win the Nepal Super League alive for the second time after defeating Lalitpur City FC (LCFC) 1-0 in the final league match on Saturday and qualifying for the playoffs.

Kathmandu desperately needed a win as a draw or loss against Lalitpur would have seen Jhapa FC qualifying for the playoffs. The header by Andres Nia Tchounkeu over a cross by Komilzhon Tozhidinov in the injury time of the first half was enough to settle the match.

Lalitpur's goalie Jeffery Baltus and Kathmandu's Anjal Shrestha were busy throughout the match despite conceding only one goal. Baltus was unable to save the header by Nia to give Kathmandu the win while Anjal saved every shot in the frame. The winning goal helped Nia win the player of the match.

A freekick by Shokhrukh Makhmudkhozhiev in the 43rd minute was one of the best moments. The ball bended towards the top far corner beating Baltus and heading towards the back of the net but hit the crossbar.

Papa Ibou Kebe and Imoh Ezekiel did everything they could, but failed to score goals for either an equaliser or a comeback for Lalitpur. Kathmandu, which started the first half with intense pressure on the opponent, also missed many chances.

Lalitpur was dominant in the second half. The dominance intensified after Amit Tamang was shown a red card for headbutting Nikhil Kadam in the 75th minute. However, Lalitpur could not take advantage of several chances created against the 10-men Kathmandu until the final whistle.

On the other hand, Birgunj United FC would have also extended its chance for the playoffs if it won against FC Butwal Lumbini in the first match on Saturday. However, Butwal Lumbini won with a goal in the 90+ injury time to not end the campaign as the bottom team in the league.



PHOTO: NSL
Players fight for the ball in the final league match of the NSL between Kathmandu Rayzrs FC and Lalitpur City FC at Dasharath Stadium on Saturday.

While the game was coming to an end at a score of 0-0, substitute Chandan Das converted a pass from Arik Bista into a last-minute goal from between the legs of goalie Deep Karki in 90+3 minutes. Bista was adjudged the player of the match.

If Birgunj had won, it would have been playing in the playoffs as Lalitpur would have been knocked out of the top four after the win by Kathmandu.

After Birgunj's chances were washed away by Butwal Lumbini, Lalitpur, which would have qualified for the playoffs even if it lost the match against Kathmandu, was looking for a win to climb to the second position in the league and earn an extra chance for the qualifiers.

Now, league-topper Pokhara Thunders FC and second-positioned Dhangadhi FC will play Qualifier 1 on December 25. The winner will book a place in the finals. The losing team will get another chance.

Third and fourth-positioned Kathmandu and Lalitpur will play the Eliminator on December 26. The winner will play Qualifier 2 on December 28 against the losing side of Qualifier 1 for a place in the finals being held on December 30.

Bangladesh beat New Zealand by nine wickets; NZ win Series 2-1

AP
New Zealand, Dec. 23

Bangladesh needed only 15 overs with the bat to complete a nine-wicket win over New Zealand in the third one-day international on Saturday, ending New Zealand's winning streak in ODIs at home at 17 matches.

After rolling New Zealand for 98 in 31.4 overs, captain Najmul Hossain Shanto made an unbeaten 51 from 42 balls and Amanul Haque 37 from 33 to lead Bangladesh to its first ODI win over the Kiwis in New Zealand in 19 attempts.

New Zealand won the three-match series 2-1 after winning the first match by 44 runs and the second by seven wickets. But Bangladesh gained a measure of revenge Saturday and primed itself for the upcoming Twenty20 series, bowling New Zealand out for its lowest-ever total in ODIs between the teams.

Earlier, Tanzim Hasan Sakib took 3-14 and Shoriful Islam 3-22 — both career bests — as Bangladesh rolled New Zealand cheaply to set up a dominant victory. Soumya Sarkar chipped in with 3-18 as New Zealand fell below its previous lowest ODI score against Bangladesh of 162.

Bangladesh captain Shanto was delighted to be able to choose to field when he won the toss. The McLean Park pitch usually is one of the best to bat on in New Zealand with an average first-innings score in ODIs of 239.

The largest partnership in the innings was the 36 between Will Young (26) and Tom Latham (21) for the third wicket. Only two other New Zealand batters reached double figures.

Shoriful reproduced the form that saw him take two wickets in the opening over of the first ODI, dismissing Young, Latham and Mark Chapman (2).

Sakib maintained an exacting line, giving the batters no width and completing two maidens among his seven overs. He dismissed Rachin Ravindra (8) in the fourth over to begin the New Zealand collapse, then removed Henry Nicholls (1) and Tom Blundell (4).

When the two seamers had left the host's innings in tatters, Sarkar came on and took the wickets of Josh Clarkson (16), Adam Milne (4) and Adithya Ashok (10).

The last wicket fell to Mushfiqur Rahim who took 1-36.



PHOTO: AP
Bangladesh bowler Soumya Sarkar celebrates taking the wicket of NZ's Adam Milne during the 3rd ODI in New Zealand on Saturday.

LUIS SUÁREZ IS REUNITED WITH LIONEL MESSI AT INTER MIAMI

AP
Fort Lauderdale, Dec. 23

The long-awaited reunion of Luis Suárez and Lionel Messi is now a reality, after the Uruguayan striker signed with Inter Miami on Friday for the 2024 season.

Suárez and Messi spent six seasons together at Barcelona, winning four Spanish league titles and nine other trophies — including a Champions League title — in that span. Suárez is coming off a season where he was the best player and the best striker in the Brazilian league with Gremio.

"I'm very happy and excited to take on this new challenge with Inter Miami," Suárez said. "I can't wait to get started, and I'm ready to work to make the dream of winning more titles with this great club a reality. I'm optimistic about what we can achieve together with our shared ambition."

There had been speculation for months that Suárez would join Inter Miami, especially given his relationship with Messi. Inter Miami won its first trophy — the Leagues Cup — last season shortly after Messi arrived, his signing part of an overhaul that brought elite talent like Sergio Busquets and Jordi Alba to the club, along with coach Gerardo "Tata" Martino. Busquets and Alba also played for Barcelona alongside Messi, and Martino is a former Barcelona coach.

Now, Suárez joins that mix. He turns 37 in January — Messi is 36, Busquets is 35 and Alba turns 35 in March, so Inter Miami will surely have some workloads to manage. Suárez has struggled with intense knee pain, but clearly, the lure of playing with Messi again was too strong to ignore.

"I will give my all to bring joy to these great fans I've heard so much about while I wear Inter Miami colours, and look forward to reuniting with great friends and players," Suárez said. "I'm also eager to meet my new teammates and coaches."

Man City confirmed as world's best club in 2023 after winning its fifth trophy



PHOTO: AP
Manchester City players with the trophy at the end of the Soccer Club World Cup final in Jeddah, Saudi Arabia, Friday, Dec. 22, 2023. Manchester City defeated Fluminense FC 4-0.

AP
Jeddah, Dec. 23

Pep Guardiola is happy to call Manchester City the best in the world this year, but an all-time great team? That debate must wait for years if not decades.

"Right now, I don't know," Guardiola said after City cruised to its first Club World Cup title by easily beating Fluminense 4-0 on Friday, lifting a fifth domestic and international trophy in 2023.

Guardiola is the first coach to win the FIFA club title with three different teams and compared City's status to the great Barcelona side he led to be the champion of Spain, Europe and the world in 2011.

"If people talk about the team 25 or 30 years later it means you're a really good team," he said. "Today is nice. We have been the best team in the world."

Judgment on this Man City era also must wait for the outcome of an English Premier League investigation into alleged financial wrongdoing at the club for almost a decade through 2018.

A hearing is expected late next year to examine 115 charges levelled against the club for conduct during the first nine full seasons after being bought by the royal family of Abu Dhabi. Verdicts are not expected until 2025 when City will play in the first revamped Club World Cup with 32 teams.

Guardiola's team has been unquestionably the best in Europe this year and was simply too good for overmatched Fluminense, which could ill afford unlucky bounces of the ball that left the first-time champion of South America in a two-goal hole within 27 minutes.

"We prepared the whole year for (Copa) Libertadores but not the Club World Cup," Fluminense coach Fernando Diniz said of his team being drained by winning its continental title seven weeks ago.

City led after just 40 seconds to make it a match mostly free of tension. Julián Álvarez followed up fastest to meet a rebound off a post from Nathan Aké's shot.

An own goal by Fluminense captain Nino decided the game long before Phil Foden's goal in the 72nd, guiding an Álvarez pass into an open net. Álvarez struck again in the 88th.

Victory came at a cost for City, which gave Europe a 16th title in 17 editions of FIFA's competition for continental champions.

Guardiola was the first coach to win the Club World Cup with three different teams. He led Barcelona to titles in 2009 and 2011, then with a team that won the Champions League under outgoing coach Jupp Heynckes.

Guardiola celebrated calmly his record fourth Club World Cup title as a coach — adding to Barcelona's in 2009 and '11 and with Bayern Munich in 2013 — by walking across to console Diniz with a handshake and arm on his shoulder.

In the third-place game earlier in Jeddah, African champion Al Ahly of Egypt won 4-2 against Urawa, the Asian champion from Japan. Those teams also will be at the expanded 2025 edition.

WEATHER

Sunday

Sunrise at 6:52 am, Sunset at 5:15 pm

Forecast for Nepal (Sunday)

Partly cloudy in the hilly areas of Koshi Province, Bagmati Province and Gandaki Province and mainly fair in rest of the country. Chances of light snowfall at one or two places of the high hilly and mountainous region of Koshi Province and Gandaki Province.

Expected Temp.: 18 - 20°C
Rain Probability: ...%

Saturday's Weather Record

Stations	Max. temp. (C)	Min. temp. (C)	Rain (mm)
Dadeldhura	16.8	5.4	0.0
Dipayal	24.4	6.1	0.0
Dhangadi	26.0	9.8	0.0
Birendranagar	23.2	7.5	0.0
Nepalgunj	25.5	11.7	0.0
Jumla	18.6	-1.3	0.0
Ghorahi	23.6	9.0	0.0
Pokhara	21.5	8.0	0.0
Bhairahawa	27.5	10.0	0.0
Simara	27.8	13.6	0.0
Kathmandu	18.3	6.2	0.0
Okhaldhunga	17.7	8.3	0.0
Taplejung	17.3	7.0	0.0
Dhankuta	23.4	10.5	0.0
Biratnagar	27.4	10.8	0.0
Jomsom	17.0	-3.5	0.0*
Dharan	27.0	16.0	0.0*
Lumle	18.5	6.5	0.0*
Janakpur	29.8	15.0	0.0*
Jiri	18.1	3.7	0.0*

NEPAL RASTRA BANK

FOREIGN EXCHANGE DEPARTMENT

EXCHANGE RATES

December 24, 2023

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
Indian Rupee	100	Rs. 160.00	Rs. 160.15

Open Market Exchange Rates
For the purpose of Nepal Rastra Bank

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
U.S. Dollar	1	Rs. 132.73	Rs. 133.33
Euro	1	Rs. 146.35	Rs. 147.01
Pound Sterling	1	Rs. 169.08	Rs. 169.85
Swiss Franc	1	Rs. 155.48	Rs. 156.18
Australian Dollar	1	Rs. 90.35	Rs. 90.76
Canadian Dollar	1	Rs. 100.00	Rs. 100.45
Singapore Dollar	1	Rs. 100.29	Rs. 100.74
Japanese Yen	10	Rs. 9.34	Rs. 9.39
Chinese Yuan	1	Rs. 18.63	Rs. 18.71
Saudi Arab Riyal	1	Rs. 35.39	Rs. 35.55
Qatari Riyal	1	Rs. 36.41	Rs. 36.58
Thai Bhat	1	Rs. 3.84	Rs. 3.86
UAE Dirham	1	Rs. 36.14	Rs. 36.31
Malaysian Ringgit	1	Rs. 28.66	Rs. 28.78
South Korean Won	100	Rs. 10.23	Rs. 10.27
Swedish Kronar	1	Rs. 13.23	Rs. 13.28
Danish Kronar	1	Rs. 19.63	Rs. 19.72
Hong Kong Dollar	1	Rs. 16.99	Rs. 17.06
Kuwaiti Dinar	1	Rs. 432.26	Rs. 434.21
Bahrain Dinar	1	Rs. 352.05	Rs. 353.64

Note: Under the present system the open market exchange rates quoted by different banks may differ.

Published by Executive Chairman **Bishnu Prasad Subedi** and General Manager **Lal Bahadur Airi** for the Gorkhapatra Corporation • Printed at G.S. Press, Kathmandu • Acting Editor-in-Chief: **Bhimsen Thapaliya**
Phone: Editorial 5322279 • Advertisement 5327493, 5331394 • Distribution 5320638 • E-mail: mgorkhapatra@gmail.com, trnfeatures@hotmail.com • Registered No. 29/028/022 • G.P.O. 30/053/54

Sunday, December 24, 2023
Poush 8, 2080 | Nepal Sambat 1144 | Thinllatwho Trayodashi

NATION'S 1ST ENGLISH BROADSHEET

risingnepaldaily.com
Vol. LIX, No. 8 | Pages 8 | Rs. 5 | Biratnagar Edition

THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL

BIRATNAGAR IS CENTRE OF POLITICAL REVOLUTION: PRESIDENT

RSS
Biratnagar, Dec 23

President Ramchandra Paudel has laid emphasis on building self-reliant and prosperous economy.

Inaugurating the Democratic Fighters' Honor Ceremony and industrialists' conclave here on Saturday, President Paudel viewed industrialists could play important role to form socialism-oriented economy.

President Paudel informed governments' initiatives to recover the national economy dented by COVID-19 has showed positive results. He however said country's economy is not up to the mark- revenue targets are missed; and industries not operated in full scale.

He reminded various personalities who had invaluable role for democracy and freedoms in the country.

According to him, Biratnagar is the provenance of both political and industrial revolutions. It houses the oldest Biratnagar Jute Mill where the labour movement was initiated.

» SEE PAGE 6



PHOTO: RSS

President Ramchandra Paudel being honoured at the Democratic Fighters' Honor Ceremony and Industrialists' conclave in Biratnagar on Saturday.

PM urges to promote organ donation campaign

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 23



Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has urged all Nepalis to have a positive attitude towards organ transplantation and contribute to it from their respective places.

While addressing the first national transplant conference organised by the Martyr Dharma Bhakta Mathema National Transplant Centre and Organ Transplant Society Nepal in Kathmandu on Saturday, Prime Minister Prachanda said, "I have personally declared my intention to donate my organs. I urge all my brothers and sisters to consider that donating organs that turn into ashes after death could give a new life to many individuals."

Acknowledging the commendable efforts of the National Transplantation Centre in advocating for organ donation after brain death, he expressed concern about reluctance among the general public regarding such donations.

"As human beings, it is our collective responsibility to make efforts towards saving the patients grappling with the life-threatening conditions caused by the liver, kidney, heart, lung, and other organ failures," he added.

"Hence, I urge all Nepalis to actively participate from their individual place, by having a positive mindset towards the national campaign for organ transplantation," the Prime Minister said.

He further affirmed the government's commitment to extending all forms of support and cooperation to advance this significant campaign aimed at saving the patients whose lives are at risk due to organ failure.

Highlighting the significance of the conference in advancing quality healthcare, he said the conference would serve as a pivotal milestone to pave the way for more effective services in the future by addressing the complexities in the field of organ transplant.

Underscoring the conference's significance, he said the conference would play an important role in strengthening the nation's health services.

This conference of the organ transplantation experts to exchange both national and international experiences stands as a crucial platform to confront with the challenges prevalent in the field of organ transplants, he added.

Prime Minister Prachanda said, "The suggestions and conclusions drawn from this conference will hold a significant importance in driving qualitative transformation within our health services."

He said the government was dedicated to implement improvements in this realm based on the recommendations and outcomes derived from the conference.

He further said that during his second tenure as Prime Minister, a decision was made to allocate land for the expansion of Martyr Dharma Bhakta Mathema National Transplant Centre.

"The government remains committed to completing the pending tasks concerning this matter within his tenure," he added.

Once successful in Nepal, bio-gas could still be alternative to LP gas

- Installation of bio-gas plants falls to 10,000 a year from 40,000
- Low subsidy, migration, urbanization slow installation

BY MODNATH DHAKAL
Kathmandu, Dec. 23



The 15th Periodic Plan of Nepal implemented in the fiscal year (FY) 2019/20 had envisaged installing 200,000 domestic bio-gas (DBG) plants.

It also had a plan to replace about 40,000 tonnes of Liquefied Petroleum Gas (LPG) through the installation of 500 large biogas plants.

TRN SPECIAL

The second Nationally Determined Contribution (NDC), 2020 included the same plan with a strategy to install an additional 200,000 household biogas plants and 500 large scale biogas (LBG) plants by 2025.

But the country currently has altogether 419,779 domestic bio-gas plants and 348 large biogas plants.

Meanwhile, the government as well as international donors' support to bio-gas, which has been one of the major sources of alternative renewable energy and low-carbon technology, has significantly fallen over the years.

Increasing migration to cities, rising construction cost and diminishing support from the donors and government have detrimental impacts on the development and growth of bio-gas plants in Nepal.

Now, the Alternative Energy Promotion Centre (AEPC), the regulatory and implementing agency in the alternative energy sector, has no donors working with it in the bio-gas sector.

Earlier, institutions like the SNV Netherland Development Organisation, World Bank and TFW Germany were providing financial and technical supports to the AEPC.

Nepal once witnessed the construction of about 40,000 bio-gas plants in a year, but now the number has fallen to below 10,000. The AEPC has a target to construct 10,000 plants this fiscal year 2023/24, but is not hopeful of meeting the target.

To meet this target, about Rs. 300 million is needed, but the alternative energy promotion body has the budget of only Rs. 50 million for subsidy.

A success story

Bio-gas sector is one of the areas that Nepal excelled and the country exported its GGC 2017 model in bio-gas plant construction to various African countries as well, said Nawa Raj Dhakal, Executive Director of the AEPC.

About a decade ago, construction of bio-gas plant started revolutionising the rural areas in Nepal by providing clean energy through inexpensive methods. The government provided a good amount of grant covering more than half of the construction cost of the bio-gas plant.

In 1999/2000, a bio-gas plan would cost about Rs. 15,000 and entire money would be subsidised by the government, said Bishnu Prasad Poudel, who worked at a private-biogas company then.

According to him, there was a huge attraction to the bio-bas plant as many families in his work area in Nawalparasi (West) used to rear cattle and work in farms.

But now, the number of families involved in animal husbandry has been significantly reduced, and even in the dairies in villages one can see higher number of people coming to buy milk than to sell it.

Some households in Bardaghat Municipality of Nawalparasi West have abandoned bio-gas plants in their courtyards and LPG cylinder has become a permanent feature of their kitchen. This has been a trend across the country, said Dhakal.

While the cost of construction materials went up significantly after the 2015 earthquake, the government subsidy began decreasing. The government did not show interest in providing subsidy for the construction of bio-gas plants after the development partners pulled their hands out from the project.

Need of 70 per cent subsidy

As per Dhakal, the current government grant covers only 25 to 30 per cent of the total construction cost of the bio-gas plant.

The AEPC had proposed to raise this subsidy to 50 to 60 per cent to promote bio-gas and attract households to this, but it was not approved.

President of Nepal Bio-gas Promotion Association (NBPA), Prakash Subedi, said that the subsidy should be increased up to 70 per cent of the total cost of the plant. Currently, it costs about Rs. 80,000 in average for the construction of a bio-gas plant.

Meanwhile, the bio-gas project of Nepal has been included in the Clean Development Mechanism (CDM) and the country is receiving about Rs. 2 billion a year, said Subedi.

According to the United Nations Framework Convention on

» SEE PAGE 6

We are still in transitional phase: Deuba

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 23



Nepali Congress president Sher Bahadur Deuba has said that the country has still been in a transitional phase politically.

Speaking at the inaugural session of the NC Bagmati Province conference held in Kathmandu on Saturday, Deuba recalled the NC's lead role to establish inclusive proportional democratic system.

"The system provisioned representation of the Aadibasi Janajati, disabled and others in the state mechanisms," he said. The NC chief said the NC regained the position of the largest party from the last general election as the present electoral system does not allow a single party to secure a majority.

He underlined the need for unity in the party to make the NC stronger from grassroots. "I would like to urged leaders of Bagmati Province to play more lead role to lead all Nepal," he said.

"The NC succeeded to become the largest party due to our friends' sacrifice and hard work. Friends, you all should involve to make the party strong from grassroots," he said.

Deuba stressed the importance of developing the feeling of cooperation between each other in the party by forging reconciliation. He said the party have leaders and workers who have contributed to the NC without any expectation.

» SEE PAGE 6

Govt has prioritised good governance: Minister Sharma

BY OUR CORRESPONDENTS
Dharan / Hile, Dec. 23



Minister for Communication and Information Technology Rekha Sharma has said that the government media is just not of government alone but of all, and they should disseminate the messages of the government to the public and vice versa.

Road to Justice

Speaking at a press conference in Sunsari on Saturday, Minister Sharma said that good governance and service delivery would be prioritised. She said that the government had been successful in taking legal action against those taking fake Bhutanese refugees to the United States, against the gold smugglers, and those involved in Lalita Niwas land scam. She said that in a democracy, everyone should be treated equally.

Minister Sharma said that the government and private sectors should move hand in hand for the development of information technology. Stating that the government would work in the areas of policy, law and infrastructure construction for the development of information and communication technology, she said that new policies were also being formulated.

» SEE PAGE 6

Chatty robot helps seniors fight loneliness through AI companionship

AP
Coral Spings, Dec. 23

Joyce Loaiza lives alone, but when she returns to her apartment at a Florida senior community, the retired office worker often has a chat with a friendly female voice that asks about her day.

A few miles away, the same voice comforted 83-year-old Deanna Dezern when her friend died. In central New York, it plays games and music for 92-year-old Marie Broadbent, who is blind and in hospice, and in Washington state, it helps 83-year-old Jan Worrell make new friends.

The women are some of the first in the country to receive the robot ElliQ, whose creators, Intuition Robotics, and senior assistance officials say is the only device using artificial intelligence specifically designed to alleviate the loneliness and isolation experienced by many older Americans.

"It's entertaining. You can actually talk to her," said Loaiza, 81, whose ElliQ in suburban Fort Lauderdale nicknamed her "Jellybean" for no particular reason. "She'll make comments like, 'I would go outside if I had hands, but I can't hold an umbrella.'"

The device, which looks like a small table lamp, has an eyeless, mouthless head that lights up and swivels. It remembers each user's interests and their conversations, helping tailor future chats, which can be as deep as the meaning of life or as light as the horoscope.

ElliQ tells jokes, plays music and provides inspirational quotes. On an accompanying video screen, it provides tours of cities and museums. The device leads exercises, asks about the owner's health and gives reminders to take medications and drink water. It can also host video calls and contact relatives, friends or doctors in an emergency.

Intuition Robotics says none of the conversations are heard by the company, with the information staying on each owner's device.

Intuition Robotics CEO Dor Skuler said the idea for ElliQ came before he launched his Israeli company eight years ago. His widowed grandfather needed an aide, but the first didn't work out. The replacement, though, understood his grandfather's love of classical music and his "quirky sense of humor."

Skuler realized a robot could fill that companionship gap by adapting to each senior's personality and interests.

"It's not just about (ElliQ's) utility. It's about friendship, companionship and empathy," Skuler said. "That just did not exist anywhere."

The average user interacts with ElliQ more than 30 times daily, even six months after receiving it, and more than 90% report lower levels of loneliness, he said.

The robots are mostly distributed by assistance agencies in New York, Florida, Michigan, Nevada and Washington state, but can also be purchased individually for $600 a year and a $250 installation fee. Skuler wouldn't say how many ElliQs have been distributed so far, but the goal is to have more than 100,000 out within five years.

That worries Brigham Young University psychology professor Julianne Holt-Lunstad, who studies the detrimental effects loneliness has on health and mortality.

Sunday, December 24, 2023
Poush 8, 2080 | Nepal Sambat 1144 | Thinllatwho Trayodashi

NATION'S 1ST ENGLISH BROADSHEET

risingnepaldaily.com
Vol. LIX, No. 8 | Pages 8 | Rs. 5 | Kohalpur Edition

THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL

BIRATNAGAR IS CENTRE OF POLITICAL REVOLUTION: PRESIDENT

RSS
Biratnagar, Dec 23

President Ramchandra Paudel has laid emphasis on building self-reliant and prosperous economy.

Inaugurating the Democratic Fighters' Honor Ceremony and industrialists' conclave here on Saturday, President Paudel viewed industrialists could play important role to form socialism-oriented economy.

President Paudel informed governments' initiatives to recover the national economy dented by COVID-19 has showed positive results. He however said country's economy is not up to the mark- revenue targets are missed; and industries not operated in full scale.

He reminded various personalities who had invaluable role for democracy and freedoms in the country.

According to him, Biratnagar is the provenance of both political and industrial revolutions. It houses the oldest Biratnagar Jute Mill where the labour movement was initiated.

» SEE PAGE 6



PHOTO: RSS

President Ramchandra Paudel being honoured at the Democratic Fighters' Honor Ceremony and Industrialists' conclave in Biratnagar on Saturday.

PM urges to promote organ donation campaign

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 23



Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has urged all Nepalis to have a positive attitude towards organ transplantation and contribute to it from their respective places.

While addressing the first national transplant conference organised by the Martyr Dharma Bhakta Mathema National Transplant Centre and Organ Transplant Society Nepal in Kathmandu on Saturday, Prime Minister Prachanda said, "I have personally declared my intention to donate my organs. I urge all my brothers and sisters to consider that donating organs that turn into ashes after death could give a new life to many individuals."

Acknowledging the commendable efforts of the National Transplantation Centre in advocating for organ donation after brain death, he expressed concern about reluctance among the general public regarding such donations.

"As human beings, it is our collective responsibility to make efforts towards saving the patients grappling with the life-threatening conditions caused by the liver, kidney, heart, lung, and other organ failures," he added.

"Hence, I urge all Nepalis to actively participate from their individual place, by having a positive mindset towards the national campaign for organ transplantation," the Prime Minister said.

He further affirmed the government's commitment to extending all forms of support and cooperation to advance this significant campaign aimed at saving the patients whose lives are at risk due to organ failure.

Highlighting the significance of the conference in advancing quality healthcare, he said the conference would serve as a pivotal milestone to pave the way for more effective services in the future by addressing the complexities in the field of organ transplant.

Underscoring the conference's significance, he said the conference would play an important role in strengthening the nation's health services.

This conference of the organ transplantation experts to exchange both national and international experiences stands as a crucial platform to confront with the challenges prevalent in the field of organ transplants, he added.

Prime Minister Prachanda said, "The suggestions and conclusions drawn from this conference will hold a significant importance in driving qualitative transformation within our health services."

He said the government was dedicated to implement improvements in this realm based on the recommendations and outcomes derived from the conference.

He further said that during his second tenure as Prime Minister, a decision was made to allocate land for the expansion of Martyr Dharma Bhakta Mathema National Transplant Centre.

"The government remains committed to completing the pending tasks concerning this matter within his tenure," he added.

Once successful in Nepal, bio-gas could still be alternative to LP gas

- Installation of bio-gas plants falls to 10,000 a year from 40,000
- Low subsidy, migration, urbanization slow installation

BY MODNATH DHAKAL
Kathmandu, Dec. 23



The 15th Periodic Plan of Nepal implemented in the fiscal year (FY) 2019/20 had envisaged installing 200,000 domestic bio-gas (DBG) plants.

It also had a plan to replace about 40,000 tonnes of Liquefied Petroleum Gas (LPG) through the installation of 500 large biogas plants.

TRN SPECIAL

The second Nationally Determined Contribution (NDC), 2020 included the same plan with a strategy to install an additional 200,000 household biogas plants and 500 large scale biogas (LBG) plants by 2025.

But the country currently has altogether 419,779 domestic bio-gas plants and 348 large biogas plants.

Meanwhile, the government as well as international donors' support to bio-gas, which has been one of the major sources of alternative renewable energy and low-carbon technology, has significantly fallen over the years.

Increasing migration to cities, rising construction cost and diminishing support from the donors and government have detrimental impacts on the development and growth of bio-gas plants in Nepal.

Now, the Alternative Energy Promotion Centre (AEPC), the regulatory and implementing agency in the alternative energy sector, has no donors working with it in the bio-gas sector.

Earlier, institutions like the SNV Netherland Development Organisation, World Bank and TFW Germany were providing financial and technical supports to the AEPC.

Nepal once witnessed the construction of about 40,000 bio-gas plants in a year, but now the number has fallen to below 10,000. The AEPC has a target to construct 10,000 plants this fiscal year 2023/24, but is not hopeful of meeting the target.

To meet this target, about Rs. 300 million is needed, but the alternative energy promotion body has the budget of only Rs. 50 million for subsidy.

A success story

Bio-gas sector is one of the areas that Nepal excelled and the country exported its GGC 2017 model in bio-gas plant construction to various African countries as well, said Nawa Raj Dhakal, Executive Director of the AEPC.

About a decade ago, construction of bio-gas plant started revolutionising the rural areas in Nepal by providing clean energy through inexpensive methods. The government provided a good amount of grant covering more than half of the construction cost of the bio-gas plant.

In 1999/2000, a bio-gas plan would cost about Rs. 15,000 and entire money would be subsidised by the government, said Bishnu Prasad Poudel, who worked at a private-biogas company then.

According to him, there was a huge attraction to the bio-bas plant as many families in his work area in Nawalparasi (West) used to rear cattle and work in farms.

But now, the number of families involved in animal husbandry has been significantly reduced, and even in the dairies in villages one can see higher number of people coming to buy milk than to sell it.

Some households in Bardaghat Municipality of Nawalparasi West have abandoned bio-gas plants in their courtyards and LPG cylinder has become a permanent feature of their kitchen. This has been a trend across the country, said Dhakal.

While the cost of construction materials went up significantly after the 2015 earthquake, the government subsidy began decreasing. The government did not show interest in providing subsidy for the construction of bio-gas plants after the development partners pulled their hands out from the project.

Need of 70 per cent subsidy

As per Dhakal, the current government grant covers only 25 to 30 per cent of the total construction cost of the bio-gas plant.

The AEPC had proposed to raise this subsidy to 50 to 60 per cent to promote bio-gas and attract households to this, but it was not approved.

President of Nepal Bio-gas Promotion Association (NBPA), Prakash Subedi, said that the subsidy should be increased up to 70 per cent of the total cost of the plant. Currently, it costs about Rs. 80,000 in average for the construction of a bio-gas plant.

Meanwhile, the bio-gas project of Nepal has been included in the Clean Development Mechanism (CDM) and the country is receiving about Rs. 2 billion a year, said Subedi.

According to the United Nations Framework Convention on

» SEE PAGE 6

We are still in transitional phase: Deuba

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 23



Nepali Congress president Sher Bahadur Deuba has said that the country has still been in a transitional phase politically.

Speaking at the inaugural session of the NC Bagmati Province conference held in Kathmandu on Saturday, Deuba recalled the NC's lead role to establish inclusive proportional democratic system.

"The system provisioned representation of the Aadibasi Janajati, disabled and others in the state mechanisms," he said. The NC chief said the NC regained the position of the largest party from the last general election as the present electoral system does not allow a single party to secure a majority.

He underlined the need for unity in the party to make the NC stronger from grassroots. "I would like to urged leaders of Bagmati Province to play more lead role to lead all Nepal," he said.

"The NC succeeded to become the largest party due to our friends' sacrifice and hard work. Friends, you all should involve to make the party strong from grassroots," he said.

Deuba stressed the importance of developing the feeling of cooperation between each other in the party by forging reconciliation. He said the party have leaders and workers who have contributed to the NC without any expectation.

» SEE PAGE 6

Govt has prioritised good governance: Minister Sharma

BY OUR CORRESPONDENTS
Dharan / Hile, Dec. 23



Minister for Communication and Information Technology Rekha Sharma has said that the government media is just not of government alone but of all, and they should disseminate the messages of the government to the public and vice versa.

Road to Justice

Speaking at a press conference in Sunsari on Saturday, Minister Sharma said that good governance and service delivery would be prioritised. She said that the government had been successful in taking legal action against those taking fake Bhutanese refugees to the United States, against the gold smugglers, and those involved in Lalita Niwas land scam. She said that in a democracy, everyone should be treated equally.

Minister Sharma said that the government and private sectors should move hand in hand for the development of information technology. Stating that the government would work in the areas of policy, law and infrastructure construction for the development of information and communication technology, she said that new policies were also being formulated.

» SEE PAGE 6

Chatty robot helps seniors fight loneliness through AI companionship

AP
Coral Spings, Dec. 23

Joyce Loaiza lives alone, but when she returns to her apartment at a Florida senior community, the retired office worker often has a chat with a friendly female voice that asks about her day.

A few miles away, the same voice comforted 83-year-old Deanna Dezern when her friend died. In central New York, it plays games and music for 92-year-old Marie Broadbent, who is blind and in hospice, and in Washington state, it helps 83-year-old Jan Worrell make new friends.

The women are some of the first in the country to receive the robot ElliQ, whose creators, Intuition Robotics, and senior assistance officials say is the only device using artificial intelligence specifically designed to alleviate the loneliness and isolation experienced by many older Americans.

"It's entertaining. You can actually talk to her," said Loaiza, 81, whose ElliQ in suburban Fort Lauderdale nicknamed her "Jellybean" for no particular reason. "She'll make comments like, 'I would go outside if I had hands, but I can't hold an umbrella.'"

The device, which looks like a small table lamp, has an eyeless, mouthless head that lights up and swivels. It remembers each user's interests and their conversations, helping tailor future chats, which can be as deep as the meaning of life or as light as the horoscope.

ElliQ tells jokes, plays music and provides inspirational quotes. On an accompanying video screen, it provides tours of cities and museums. The device leads exercises, asks about the owner's health and gives reminders to take medications and drink water. It can also host video calls and contact relatives, friends or doctors in an emergency.

Intuition Robotics says none of the conversations are heard by the company, with the information staying on each owner's device.

Intuition Robotics CEO Dor Skuler said the idea for ElliQ came before he launched his Israeli company eight years ago. His widowed grandfather needed an aide, but the first didn't work out. The replacement, though, understood his grandfather's love of classical music and his "quirky sense of humor."

Skuler realized a robot could fill that companionship gap by adapting to each senior's personality and interests.

"It's not just about (ElliQ's) utility. It's about friendship, companionship and empathy," Skuler said. "That just did not exist anywhere."

The average user interacts with ElliQ more than 30 times daily, even six months after receiving it, and more than 90% report lower levels of loneliness, he said.

The robots are mostly distributed by assistance agencies in New York, Florida, Michigan, Nevada and Washington state, but can also be purchased individually for $600 a year and a $250 installation fee. Skuler wouldn't say how many ElliQs have been distributed so far, but the goal is to have more than 100,000 out within five years.

That worries Brigham Young University psychology professor Julianne Holt-Lunstad, who studies the detrimental effects loneliness has on health and mortality.